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CM announces heat safeguards for commuters, workers and students

NATION: Pg 5

Rallies, road shows in WB felt like pilgrimage: PM

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‘Was scared to work with Meryl in The Devil Wears Prada’

AMID CHARGES, COUNTER-CHARGES BY BJP, TMC

High-octane election campaign for phase-2 wraps up in Bengal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Campaigning for the second and final phase of West Bengal Assembly polls came to an end on Monday amid a fierce high-stakes political battle dominated by exchanges over SIR, infiltration, corruption and unemployment, with both the BJP and the TMC making a slew of promises to voters across 142 constituencies.

During the high-octane campaign, the BJP leadership accused the ruling TMC of turning West Bengal into a haven for infiltrators, while Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee alleged that the saffron party was indulging in divisive politics, attempting to bifurcate the state and discouraging consumption of fish and eggs.

Addressing a gathering after leading a road show at West Bengal's Behala on Monday, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said Central forces would



Polling personnel with election materials arrive in riverine areas ahead of the second phase of the West Bengal Assembly elections, in North 24 Parganas district

remain deployed in the state for at least seven more days after the elections, even if the BJP comes to power. He urged the voters to cast their votes without fear.

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressed a poll rally in Barrackpore. He said, "Barrackpore had given strength to the first war of Inde-

pendence in 1857; this very land today is paving way for a change in West Bengal."

Mamata Banerjee focused on her constituency in Bhaba-

POLL KEY POINTS

- » **ELECTORATE:** 3.21 crore voters (1.64 cr men, 1.57 cr women, 792 third gender) across 142 constituencies
- » **POLLING SETUP:** 41,001 booths; 100% webcasting
- » **SECURITY:** 2,321 central force companies across 7 districts
- » **MONITORING:** 142 general, 95 police, 100 expenditure observers; drones deployed
- » **MAX DEPLOYMENT:** Kolkata (273 companies)

NINTH TRADE DEAL WITH DEVELOPED NATION

India locks in \$20 bn investment commitment from New Zealand

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and New Zealand on Monday signed a sweeping free trade agreement that officials from both sides described as a landmark step in bilateral ties, opening full duty-free access for all Indian exports to the island nation and laying out a road-map for investment, services, and mobility.

The agreement, signed in the presence of Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and New Zealand's Trade and Investment Minister Todd McClay, is expected to come into force by the end of the year, subject to approval by New Zealand's Parliament and clearance from India's Union Cabinet.

Under the pact, New Zealand will eliminate tariffs on 100 per cent of Indian exports across all product categories. This includes sectors such as textiles and apparel, leather and footwear, gems and jewellery, engineering goods, and processed foods. Previously, New Zealand imposed tariffs of up to 10 per cent on several key Indian exports, including ceramics, carpets, automobiles, and auto components.

The agreement also includes a long-term investment commitment of USD 20 billion from New Zealand over a period of 15 years. This marks only the second instance where India has secured such a pledge within a trade deal framework, following a USD 100 billion commitment made earlier by the European bloc EFTA.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said the agreement would have wide-ranging benefits across segments of society. In a social media post, he noted that the investment commitment would deepen collaboration in agriculture, manufacturing, innovation, and technology. He added that the pact would support farmers, youth, women, MSMEs, artisans, startups, students, and innovators.

New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon



Union Minister of Commerce and Industries Piyush Goyal with New Zealand Minister of Trade and Investment Todd McClay, in New Delhi

WHAT INDIA GAINS	WHAT NEW ZEALAND GAINS
» All Indian goods can enter New Zealand tax-free (100%)	» Easier access to Indian market for most goods (70% tariff lines)
» Key sectors benefit: clothes, footwear, jewellery, machinery, processed food	» Lower or zero taxes on items like wine, metals, medicines
» Easier access for Indian service companies (IT, education, finance, tourism)	» Can export raw materials like wood, coal, and sheep meat to India
» Indian professionals get new work visas (up to 5,000 at a time, stay up to 3 years)	
» Special pathway for Indian students with post-study work options	

WHAT INDIA PROTECTED
» Easier access to Indian market for most goods (70% tariff lines)
» Lower or zero taxes on items like wine, metals, medicines
» Can export raw materials like wood, coal, and sheep meat to India

INVESTMENT & JOBS	TRADE IMPACT
» New Zealand to invest \$20 billion over 15 years in India	» Current trade: about \$2.4 billion
» Expected boost to jobs, manufacturing, agriculture, and technology	» Target: grow to \$5 billion in 5 years

described the agreement as a "once-in-a-generation" opportunity, stating that it would give exporters access to India's 1.4 billion consumers and an economy projected to become the world's third-largest.

The two countries aim to more than double bilateral trade in goods and services to USD 5 billion within five years. Total trade between the two nations stood at about USD 2.4 billion in 2024,

including USD 1.24 billion in services such as travel, IT, and business services.

Goyal noted that the agreement is India's ninth such pact in recent years with developed economies, covering a total of 38 countries. He said the deal focuses on strengthening exports, improving agricultural productivity, expanding student mobility, and boosting investment and services.

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Central forces to stay in Bengal for 60 more days after polls

Amit Shah

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AAP SAYS READY TO MOVE COURT FOR THEIR DISQUALIFICATION

Seven rebel AAP MPs officially part of BJP

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The balance of power in the Rajya Sabha shifted on Monday after Chairman C P Radhakrishnan formally accepted the merger of seven Aam Aadmi Party MPs with the Bharatiya Janata Party, triggering a sharp political confrontation and legal threat from the AAP. The decision reduced the AAP's strength in the 245-member House from 10 to three, while the BJP's tally rose to 113, according to updated records of the Rajya Sabha Secretariat.



“IT IS WRONG TO BREAK A PARTY IN THIS MANNER”

The seven MPs, most of them from Punjab, had approached the Chairman on Friday seeking recognition as BJP members after announc-

ing a merger that they said met constitutional requirements. Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju confirmed the development, stating on social media that the Chairman had accepted the merger and that the MPs were now part of the BJP Parliamentary Party. He welcomed them to the National Democratic Alliance, invok-

ing Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership.

The MPs involved are Raghav Chadha, Ashok Mittal, Harbhajan Singh, Sandeep Pathak, Vikramjit Sahney, Swati Maliwal and Rajinder Gupta. Chadha had earlier said that two-thirds of the party's Rajya Sabha MPs had decided to merge with

Continued on P4

‘Hope of justice broken’: Kejriwal boycotts hearing before Delhi HC judge

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Aam Aadmi Party chief Arvind Kejriwal has informed Delhi High Court judge Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma that he will not participate in further proceedings in the excise policy case before her, either personally or through legal counsel, the party said on Monday. In a detailed four-page letter, Kejriwal cited what he described as a "grave miscarriage of justice" and said his decision was guided by his conscience, while also invoking the principles of Satyagraha



Arvind Kejriwal

associated with Mahatma Gandhi. Kejriwal wrote that his "hope of getting justice" from Justice Sharma had been "broken", prompting him to withdraw from the proceedings. He said the move was not taken lightly and acknowledged that it could harm his own legal position. "I understand that I may lose the opportunity to advance submissions before this Hon'ble Court and that adverse consequences in law may follow. I am prepared to bear those consequences," he stated.

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SUBMITS REVISED TARGETS FOR 2031-35 TO UN'S CLIMATE CHANGE BODY

India aims 47% emission intensity cut, 60% non-fossil power capacity by 2035

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India has formally submitted its updated climate action plan for the 2031-2035 period to the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change, outlining enhanced targets to curb emissions and expand clean energy capacity.

TAKEAWAYS

» **ENERGY TRANSITION GOAL:** About 60% installed power capacity from non-fossil sources by 2035

» Depends on technology transfer + low-cost international finance

» **CARBON SINK TARGET:** 3.5-4 billion tonnes CO equivalent via forests/tree cover by 2035 (vs 2005 baseline)

THIRD NDC SUBMISSION:

• FIRST: 2015 (for 2025)

• SECOND: 2022 (for 2030)

• LATEST: 2035 targets

» **AHEAD-OF-SCHEDULE ACHIEVEMENTS (EARLIER NDC):** 40% non-fossil power capacity achieved in 2021 (9 years early)

» 33% emission intensity reduction achieved in 2019 (11 years early)

IN its submission made on Friday, India also pledged that around 60 per cent of its cumulative installed electricity capacity will come from non-fossil fuel sources by 2035. This transition, the document noted, would depend on access to affordable international finance and the transfer of clean technologies. The plan further includes a commitment to create an additional carbon sink of 3.5 to 4 billion tonnes of carbon

Continued on P4

A woman covers herself and her child on a hot summer day, in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh, on Monday

Relief from heatwave in north likely today

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Northern India continued to reel under an intense heatwave on Monday, with temperatures soaring across several states, even as forecasters signalled possible relief beginning Tuesday through thunderstorms and gusty winds.

According to the India Meteorological Department, conditions are expected to shift across Delhi, Himachal Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, where rain and strong winds may bring a temporary dip in temperatures. The change is linked to a cyclonic circulation forming over adjoining central Pakistan, northwest Rajasthan, Punjab and Haryana, which is moving northeast and is likely to influence weather patterns in the coming days.

Monday remained punishing for large parts of the country. Banda in Uttar Pradesh emerged as the hottest location, recording 47.6 degrees Celsius, which was 5.4 degrees above normal. Akola in Maharashtra followed at 46.9 degrees Celsius, while Nagpur and other Vidarbha regions faced severe heatwave conditions. In Rajasthan, Jaisalmer recorded 46.4 degrees Celsius, and hot conditions persisted across several districts.

Haryana and Punjab also witnessed high temperatures, with Rohtak touching 44.2 degrees Celsius

Continued on P4

JAFFARPUR KALAN AREA

Police head constable who shot dead 21-year-old delivery worker arrested

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Delhi Police head constable accused of shooting dead a 21-year-old delivery agent and injuring his friend following an altercation in southwest Delhi's Jaffarpur Kalan area has been arrested, officials said on Monday.

The arrest comes within 24 hours of the incident, they said, adding that he had been hiding and was apprehended around midnight from the Jaffarpur area.

The accused, identified as Neeraj, has been posted with the local police unit, a senior police officer confirmed.

However, he was not on duty at the time of the incident, according to the officer.

In the early hours of Sunday, Neeraj allegedly opened fire at Pandav Kumar, a food



delivery agent, and his friend Krishan following a heated argument. Kumar died of a gunshot wound, while Krishan sustained injuries and is undergoing treatment.

According to police, the incident took place at around 2.30 am when the victims were standing by a road after attending a birthday celebration in the area.

TAKEAWAYS

» The arrest comes within 24 hours of the incident, they said, adding that he had been hiding and was apprehended around midnight from the Jaffarpur area

» 'He was not on duty at the time of the incident'

» The accused, identified as Neeraj, has been posted with the local police unit, a senior police officer confirmed

The bullet pierced through his chest and also hit his friend," a police officer said. Both victims were rushed to a hospital, where Kumar was declared brought dead.

The accused had immediately fled the spot after the incident.

A case of murder and attempt to murder was registered at the Jaffarpur Kalan police station, and multiple teams were formed to trace the accused.

Police said Neeraj was tracked down and arrested after sustained efforts, including local intelligence inputs and raids in the surrounding areas.

Further investigation is underway to ascertain the exact sequence of events and circumstances that led to the firing, police added.

Neeraj, who lives nearby, got into an argument with them before allegedly firing from close range.

"The accused fired at Kumar from point-blank range.

Bhalswa Dairy: Sole breadwinner among two killed in bike accident

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two 20-year-old men, including the sole breadwinner of his family, were killed after their motorcycle crashed near the Majlis Park Metro station in outer-north Delhi's Bhalswa Dairy area, police said on Monday.

The deceased have been identified as Saf Ali from Burari and Shahid from Bawana, they said.

Shahid, who worked as a labourer in a factory, is survived by his 50-year-old mother and two married sisters. His father passed away a decade ago.

The accident took place at around 9 pm on Sunday. The motorcycle, which belonged to Saf, was found abandoned near a drain along a stretch connecting the Ring Road with Wazirabad, police said.

According to preliminary inquiry, the two riders sustained grievous injuries in the accident and were taken to the Babu Jagjivan Ram Memorial



The accident took place at around 9 pm on Sunday. The motorcycle, which belonged to Saf, was found abandoned near a drain

Hospital by some passersby, where they were declared dead, a senior police officer said.

No eyewitnesses have come forward so far, he added.

Rahul, Shahid's family friend, told PTI that police informed them about the acci-

dent around 12.30 am on Sunday, while Saf's relatives had been informed earlier.

"We still don't know what exactly happened or how long they had been together," he said.

Shahid, who earlier lived with his mother in Bawana, had shifted to Sangam Vihar around two months ago to stay with his aunt, Rahul said.

"There had been tension in the area for some time, and his mother did not want her only son to get caught up in it. She sent Shahid away, thinking he would be safer with his aunt in Sangam Vihar," he said.

"But little did she know that he would never return. He was the sole earning member of the family," Rahul said, his voice breaking.

"Her future is now uncertain as she was completely dependent on Shahid," he added.

Police have launched a probe after registering a case under the relevant sections of BNS, the officer said.

DU reforms spark concern over equity, academic standards

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Recent academic reforms introduced by University of Delhi have triggered significant concern among faculty members, who warn that the changes may deepen inequality and compromise academic quality. The reforms, aligned with the National Education Policy 2020, include the introduction of one-year postgraduate (PG) programmes, a 'Semester Away' initiative, and 5% credit flexibility through online platforms like SWAYAM.

Educators argue that the one-year PG structure lacks academic depth and may weaken research training. Since a PG degree is the minimum qualification for teaching in universities, faculty fear this shift could affect the quality of future educators. Concerns have also been raised over the integration of one-year PG students directly into the second year of existing two-year programmes, potentially creating gaps in foundational knowledge. The 'Semester Away' option, which encourages students to study abroad, has been criticised for being financially exclusionary. Faculty members note that such opportunities may only be accessible to students from privileged backgrounds, thereby widening existing inequalities in higher education.

Additionally, the increased reliance on online learning platforms has sparked debate over the erosion of classroom teaching. Critics argue that



HIGHLIGHTS

» Educators argue that the one-year PG structure lacks academic depth and may weaken research training

» Since a PG degree is the min qualification for teaching in universities, faculty fear this shift could affect the quality of future educators

» The 'Semester Away' option, which encourages students to study abroad, has been criticised for being financially exclusionary

institutional learning goes beyond credit accumulation, emphasising the importance of peer interaction and student-teacher engagement. There are also apprehensions that online credits could reduce teaching hours, ultimately impacting faculty employment.

With infrastructure and faculty shortages already acknowledged, many educators believe that expanding programmes without adequate investment risks undermining the standards of public higher education.

Toddler abducted from Chandni Chowk rescued; 1 accused held after 5-day hunt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A one-and-a-half-year-old boy who was kidnapped from the crowded Chandni Chowk market in north Delhi has been rescued safely and the suspected kidnapper arrested after a five-day manhunt, officials said on Monday.

According to police, the incident was reported on April 19 when the child's mother approached the police, stating that her toddler had been abducted from the market around 7 pm.

"An FIR was immediately registered and multiple teams were formed to trace the child and identify those responsible," Deputy Commissioner of Police (North) Raja Banthia



said. During the probe, teams scanned footage from multiple CCTV cameras installed across Chandni Chowk and adjoining areas. The analysis revealed the involvement of a man and a woman, who were seen moving suspiciously in the area throughout the day and eventually abducting the child, the police said.

The suspects had been loitering in the locality since morning, apparently scouting

The suspects had been loitering in the locality since morning, apparently scouting for vulnerable children. They were also seen attempting to target other minors before successfully kidnapping the toddler, they added.

"A team meticulously tracked the movement of the suspects by analysing footage from different locations round the clock for five consecutive days. Their trail eventually led the police team to the Khajuri Khas area in northeast Delhi," the DCP said. The officer fur-

ther said that on April 24, police apprehended one of the accused -- Mohammad Firoz (32), a native of Siliguri in West Bengal -- from Khajuri Khas. The kidnapped child was also recovered safely from a rented accommodation in the area.

During interrogation, Firoz revealed that he works as an e-rickshaw driver and had recently come in contact with a woman named Kali near Hanuman Mandir in Kashmere Gate.

Kali allegedly lured Firoz with the promise of easy money and persuaded him to participate in kidnapping children, the police said.

Accused tried abducting multiple children, lured toddler with food, planned sale for Rs 20,000; one held, woman accomplice absconding

SFI opposes RSS centenary event at JMI, seeks withdrawal of permission

NEW DELHI: The SFI unit of Jamia Millia Islamia has demanded the withdrawal of permission for the programme celebrating the 100th anniversary of RSS, claiming that the function is a "direct provocation and an affront to minority students' dignity and safety".

"SFI JMI Unit, strongly and unequivocally condemns the administration for permitting and facilitating the RSS-affiliated organisation Yuva to hold a programme on our campus to celebrate the 100th anniversary of the RSS, which is happening on 28th April," the organisation said in a statement.

Condemning the university administration for permitting

the event, the Students' Federation of India shared a poster of the event, which is part of 'Yuva Kumbh' called to celebrate 100 years of Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh.

According to Yuva Kumbh's official social media page, it is described as "Yuva Kumbh unites youth to learn, lead and serve, celebrating 100 years of nation-first thought and RSS's century of service".

A JMI student and SFI member, Atikur Rehman, said that there have been a series of events held at Delhi University colleges for 100 years of RSS.

"The events have been widely protested against. Now this programme has been called in our

college as well, and there is a clear ideological divide," Rehman said.

The SFI statement further reiterated, "Celebrating its (RSS) centenary on a campus that houses thousands of minority students is a direct provocation and an affront to their dignity and safety".

SFI has demanded the immediate withdrawal of permission for the event, a formal explanation from the administration on why permission was given, and an assurance that no communal and divisive organisations will be given space on the university campus in the future.

No immediate response was available on the issue from the JMI administration. PTI

GR NOIDA: Man found dead in parked SUV with pistol in hand

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: A 30-year-old grocery shopkeeper was found dead with a gunshot wound inside a parked Scorpio vehicle in Greater Noida's Sector Ecotech-1, police said on Monday.

The deceased has been identified as Rahul Vidhuri, a local resident who lived with his wife and daughter. According to officials, the incident came to light

Late Sunday night after passersby noticed the vehicle parked in a suspicious manner and alerted the police.

A team reached the

The initial inquiry suggests that the man may have died by suicide: DCP

spot and found Vidhuri lying motionless in the driver's seat.

During the initial inspection, a pistol was recovered from his hand, along with an empty cartridge lodged in the weapon. Investigators also noted a bullet exit mark on the vehicle's glass, suggesting a shot was fired from inside the car.

Preliminary findings indicate a possible case of suicide.

However, no suicide note was found at the scene, leaving the motive unclear.

"The initial investigation suggests that the man may have died by suicide. The weapon used also appears to be illegal as no valid licence has been produced so far. We are examining all aspects," Deputy Commissioner of Police Praveen Ranjan Singh said.

The body has been sent for postmortem, and a forensic team has collected evidence. Police have recovered the victim's mobile phone and wallet and are analysing call detail records. Family members are being questioned.



arrested.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

FARIDABAD: A toddler was killed, and his mother was injured after they were hit by an SUV here, police said on Monday.

The incident occurred on Sunday night when Laxmi was travelling with her son, Pradeep, police said.

An SUV hit the duo from behind, rolling over the front wheel on Pradeep's head. Locals rushed them to a nearby private hospital, where the child was declared dead. They also caught the accused driver, Rohit, a software engineer, and handed him over to the police.

A case was registered against Rohit, and he was

IRCTC launches 14-day Northeast-Bhutan rail tour

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC) has announced a 14-day rail tour covering Assam, Meghalaya and Bhutan, with departures from Delhi Safdarjung railway station.

The itinerary includes Guwahati, Shillong and Cherapunji, followed by travel to Hasimara near the Bhutan border and entry via Phuentsholing. In Bhutan, tourists will visit Thimphu, Punakha and Paro, with key attractions such as Dochula Pass, Punakha Dzong and Tiger's Nest monastery.

The package includes train travel, three-star hotel stays, vegetarian meals, local transport and travel insurance. Prices start at Rs 1,16,545 per person for AC III, Rs 1,33,210 for AC II and Rs 1,41,540 for AC I cabin or coupe.

Officials said the tour aims to offer a structured circuit across the Northeast and Bhutan.

70 lakh trees, 8 lakh citizens: Delhi's mass plantation plan

Saplings to be planted with real-time tracking system

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has launched an ambitious plantation drive involving schools, colleges, institutions and community groups as part of its Green Action Plan 2026-27, aiming to plant over 70 lakh trees across the city.

Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa chaired a high-level meeting with representatives from over 20 educational institutions, including premier institutes, urging them to play a central role in the campaign. "Our vision is clear, we want every section of society to become a stakeholder in cleaning Delhi's air," he said.

The initiative will cover schools, universities, technical institutes, religious institutions and RWAs, with free saplings to be provided by the Forest Department along with civic bodies. The plantation activities are scheduled for the first



half of July, aligning with the monsoon season to ensure better survival of saplings.

Highlighting public participation, the minister said over 8 lakh people are being encouraged to plant trees in the name of their mothers and for Mother Nature, turning the initiative into a mass movement. "When students and citizens plant and protect trees, they will not just grow greenery, they will grow responsibility towards Delhi's future," he said.

To ensure transparency and long-term care, each planted tree will be geo-fenced and

monitored through the Green Drive 2026-27 portal. Senior officials and local representatives will oversee plantation and maintenance across all 13 zones. The government will also introduce Green Awards to recognise individuals and institutions for the best maintenance and survival of trees. "Plantation must become a culture, not just an event," Sirsa added.

Officials said the initiative aims not only to expand green cover but also to improve air quality and promote environmental awareness among students and citizens.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Crime Branch of the Delhi Police has busted an organised syndicate involved in the illegal procurement, concealment and attempted export of psychotropic medicines to the United States through international courier services, arresting five persons, including the alleged kingpin, Yasar Khan.

The operation was launched after the Anti-Gangster Squad (AGS) received a tip-off about the racket. Acting on intelligence inputs dated September 24, 2025, a specialised team conducted a raid at a courier warehouse in Moti Nagar and intercepted a suspicious parcel bound for the US.

On inspection, the parcel was found to contain commercial quantities of banned substances -- including Zolpidem, Tramadol and Diazepam -- concealed under the



guise of ordinary goods. A case was registered under relevant provisions of the NDPS Act on September 25, 2025.

Police said the interception led to the unravelling of a well-structured network operating at multiple levels. Those arrested have been identified as Abhishek Bhargava, Yasar Khan, Nitin, Neeraj Raghav and Amitesh Rai.

Investigations, including analysis of digital communications, financial transactions and courier records, revealed

that the syndicate sourced psychotropic medicines through pharmaceutical distributors using fake or manipulated invoices. The drugs were then disguised as items such as cotton or lace and shipped using forged KYC documents and fictitious sender details.

The accused allegedly maintained contact with foreign clients via platforms such as WhatsApp, while payments were routed through bank accounts and UPI channels, including those linked to a firm

The accused maintained contact with foreign clients via platforms such as WhatsApp, while payments were routed through bank accounts and UPI channels

controlled by Khan. Police added that Khan had earlier been involved in a similar NDPS case registered in Lucknow in 2023, indicating a pattern of organised activity. Further recoveries during the arrest of Bhargava, including thousands of tablets, pointed to the scale of the operation.

Officials said the bust underscores the misuse of courier networks by drug traffickers and reaffirmed their commitment to dismantling such syndicates.

WORK CURBS DURING PEAK HOURS, FOCUS ON STUDENT SAFETY...

CM announces heat safeguards for commuters, workers and students

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: With rising temperatures across the national capital, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday announced a series of measures under the Heat Wave Action Plan, stating that the government is fully prepared to minimise public hardship during extreme heat conditions.

Addressing the media at the Delhi Secretariat, the Chief Minister said, “The government is working with full preparedness at every level under the Heat Wave Action Plan. Clear guidelines have been issued to all departments to ensure that people face minimum inconvenience during the severe heat.”

Highlighting key interventions, she said cold drinking water will be made available in all DTC buses through cold



boxes to provide immediate relief to commuters. “Arrangements for cold drinking water will be made in all DTC buses so that passengers can access it whenever required during travel,” she said. Additionally, water counters near bus shelters will distribute free cold water and ORS solutions.

Focusing on worker safety, Gupta directed employers to

provide mandatory rest to labourers during peak heat hours. “Employers have been directed to ensure that workers are given rest between 1 pm and 4 pm and are not required to work under direct sunlight,” she said, adding that provision of water, shade, and basic facilities will also be the responsibility of employers.

On school safety, the Chief

Minister stressed that “the safety of children is the top priority,” directing schools to ensure drinking water, functional fans, and protection from heat.

She further said, “Every child must be given ORS solution before leaving school so that they get relief while returning home.”

The Chief Minister said

KEY POINTS

» The government is working with full preparedness at every level under the Heat Wave Action Plan. Clear guidelines have been issued to all departments to ensure that people face minimum inconvenience during the severe heat

» Employers have been directed to ensure that workers are given rest between 1 pm and 4 pm and are not required to work under direct sunlight

all departments have been instructed to strictly implement these measures.

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi and PWD have also been asked to safeguard sanitation and construction workers and halt work during peak hours.

Reassuring citizens on healthcare readiness, Gupta said hospitals are fully equipped. “Adequate arrangements of medicines and essential facilities have been made in all hospitals to deal with any emergency situation,” she said.

She added that fire, power, and water departments are on alert to ensure uninterrupted services.

“The government is fully prepared to deal with the heat wave, and our effort is to ensure that the people of Delhi face minimum difficulty during this summer season,” she said.

Delhi schools introduce hydration breaks, suspend outdoor activities

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: To shield students from heat-related ailments amid soaring temperatures and harsh afternoon sun, schools across Delhi have begun taking precautionary measures by suspending outdoor activities, shifting assemblies indoors, with some even considering early closure for junior classes.

From indoor games and hydration breaks to ORS consumption and modified dispersal timings, schools are tightening measures as the city braces for prolonged heatwave conditions.

Sudha Acharya, principal at ITL Public School in Dwarka, said all outdoor activities, including morning assembly and games, have been shifted to the school’s multipurpose hall.

“We have issued an advisory to all parents to take precautionary measures before sending their children to school. We are also planning to close the school from classes 1 to 8 from May 14 onward if the weather conditions worsen,” she said.

Mallika Preman, principal at Tagore International School in East of Kailash, said students have been advised to remain indoors during peak afternoon hours and keep themselves hydrated.

“We have suspended all outdoor activities, and students now play indoor games like carrom and chess. We have also modified the dispersal system so that students are not brought out until their parents arrive at their designated collection areas,” Preman said.

“This reduces their exposure to heat in the afternoon. Students have also been advised to wear caps or use umbrellas during dispersal,” she added.

Ritu Sharma, principal at Sovereign Public School in Rohini, said that teachers have been asked to closely



Noida: School timings revised

NOIDA: The Gautam Buddha Nagar district administration has revised school timings for all boards, including CBSE, ICSE, IB and the UP Board, in view of the prevailing heatwave conditions, officials said.

According to an order issued by the Basic Education Department Sunday, all schools will now operate from 7.30 am to 12.30 pm with effect from April 27 until further orders.

The directive has been issued in compliance with

instructions from the District Magistrate, Gautam Buddha Nagar, keeping in mind the health and safety of children amid extreme temperatures and hot winds in the district.

“The operational timings for schools and classes, including Parishad-run, private-aided and government institutions, as well as those affiliated to various boards such as CBSE, ICSE, IB and the UP Board, are hereby revised from 07:30 am to 12:30 pm,” the order stated. **MPST**

monitor students for signs of heat exhaustion.

“Our priority is to ensure that children remain safe and comfortable during school hours. We are encouraging them to carry water bottles, avoid direct sun exposure and immediately report any discomfort. We have also arranged shaded rest areas and indoor engagement activities to reduce heat exposure,” she said.

The Directorate of Education (DoE) has launched a ‘Beat the Heat’ initiative for government, government-aided and private unaided recognised schools in Delhi in view of the heatwave conditions forecast by the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The initiative follows the Heat Wave Action Plan issued by the Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) and aims to protect students from

heat-related illnesses while promoting hydration, environmental awareness and care for animals and birds.

Under the initiative, schools have been directed to ring a ‘hydration bell’ daily in the penultimate period, during which every student will consume oral rehydration solution (ORS). Teachers will also briefly explain the importance of staying hydrated.

Schools have also been encouraged to create ‘cool corners’ with earthen water pots, promote a ‘one child-one plant’ green mission and appoint student volunteers as ‘Jal Mitras’ to place and refill water bowls for birds and stray animals, the advisory said.

DoE orders water access, heat awareness, teacher training, helplines; schools to submit action taken reports by April 28

Delhi Assembly nominates 14 MLAs to MCD

Move aims to align civic governance with legislative priorities across Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Legislative Assembly has nominated 14 Members of the Legislative Assembly (MLAs) to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) for the financial year 2026–27.

According to an official notification issued by the Assembly Secretariat, the nominations have been made by the Speaker under Section 3(3)(b) (iii) of the Municipal Corporation Act, 1957. The move is aimed at ensuring representation of elected legislators in the functioning of the civic body.

“The newly nominated members are expected to play a key role in aligning civic policies with legislative priorities and addressing issues affecting residents across the Capital”

The nominated MLAs include Raj Karan Khatri (Narela), Tilak Ram Gupta (Tri Nagar), Poonam Sharma (Wazirpur), Som Dutt (Sadar Bazar), Vishesh Ravi (Karol Bagh), Kailash Gangwal (Madipur), Shyam Sharma (Hari Nagar), Kailash Gahlot (Bijwasan), Kuldeep Solanki

(Palam), Virender Singh Kadian (Delhi Cantt), Umang Bajaj (Rajender Nagar), Satish Upadhyay (Malviya Nagar), Kartar Singh Tanwar (Chhatarpur), and Ravinder Singh Negi (Patparganj).

Officials said the nominated members will represent the Assembly in MCD proceed-

ings and contribute to civic decision-making, coordination, and oversight.

The nomination of MLAs to the MCD is a statutory provision aimed at strengthening coordination between the legislative and municipal arms of governance, particularly in areas such as urban infrastructure, sanitation, public health, and local development.

The newly nominated members are expected to play a key role in aligning civic policies with legislative priorities and addressing issues affecting residents across the capital.

Bomb threats to four Delhi schools declared hoax

NEW DELHI: Bomb threats sent via email to four schools in Delhi, including three Army Public School branches and a CRPF School, triggered panic on Monday but were later declared a hoax, officials said.

Fire tenders and police teams rushed to the campuses, including Dhaura Kuan, Delhi Cantt, Shankar Vihar and Dwarka Sector 14, and carried out evacuation and searches.

“Nothing suspicious was found at any location,” a Delhi Fire Service official said. Students and staff were safely evacuated as a precaution. **MPST**

MCD issues guidelines to deal with rising temp

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi’s (MCD) Education Committee on Monday issued strict guidelines for schools to deal with the rising heat and a possible heatwave in the national capital, in line with measures taken by the Delhi government.

MCD education committee chairman Yogesh Verma said the directions have been issued for all corporation-run and affiliated schools, keeping in view the increasing heat in the capital and the possibility of a heatwave.

“On the lines of the Delhi



government, all necessary precautionary steps are being taken in MCD schools with children’s safety and health as the top priority. The decision has been taken considering the warning issued by the India Meteorological Department (IMD),” Verma said in a statement.

He added that instructions have been given to limit outdoor assemblies in schools and to hold them in shaded or indoor spaces. A ban has also been imposed on holding classes in the open.

To prevent dehydration among students, Verma said directions have been issued to implement a “water bell” system, under which students will be encouraged to drink water every 45-60 minutes.

Availability of clean and cool drinking water in schools will also be ensured, he added.

“Schools have been instructed to implement a ‘buddy system’ and encour-

age students to take care of each other. They have also been advised to keep students away from outdoor sports activities,” Verma said in the statement.

He added that awareness sessions related to heatwaves should be organised in all schools so that students can be informed about protection from heat, adequate water intake and identification of symptoms. Immediate first aid and medical assistance, if required, will also be ensured.

According to officials, MCD runs more than 1,500 primary schools and serves more than 8 lakh students in the national capital.

News at a glance

DELIVERY AGENT FOUND DEAD INSIDE IRON BOX

GURUGRAM: The body of a 24-year-old delivery agent, allegedly murdered in Gurugram’s Sector 54, was found stuffed inside an iron box in a slum area. The deceased, identified as Aman from Bihar’s Saharsa district, had been living in Gurugram for work. His brother lodged a complaint after being informed by one of Aman’s friends about the murder. Police recovered the body on Sunday evening and sent it for postmortem. Officials said the body bore multiple sharp weapon injuries, estimated to be three to four days old. A woman, who was in a live-in relationship with Aman, and her associate have been booked.

TWO CAR BLAZES REPORTED IN NOIDA, ALL SAFE

NOIDA: Two cars caught fire in separate incidents in Noida on Monday, with no injuries reported, officials said. In the first case around 12.18 am in Sector 121, a parked 2018 CNG-petrol car caught fire after electrical wires fell on it. Fire tenders reached the spot and doused the flames. In another incident at 11.40 am, a 2019 petrol car caught fire while moving on the Faridabad-Noida-Ghaziabad expressway. Officials said the blaze started in the engine due to overheating. All six occupants exited safely.

Delhi govt holds TB screening camp

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government organised an Ayushman Arogya Shivir at Delhi Government Dispensary (DGD) Bakarwala as part of the ongoing TB Mukht Bharat Abhiyan, focusing on early detection and awareness of tuberculosis.

The camp, held near JJ Colony Bakarwala, aimed to strengthen community outreach and provide accessible healthcare services. Health Minister Dr. Pankaj Kumar Singh reiterated the government’s commitment to eliminating TB and highlighted the importance of timely diagnosis. “Tuberculosis remains a signif-

icant public health challenge, but it is both preventable and curable with timely intervention. Through initiatives like the Ayushman Arogya Shivirs, we are taking healthcare closer to the people, focusing on early detection and awareness,” he said.

During the camp, 146 individuals underwent chest X-ray screening using a portable device for on-site diagnosis. In suspected cases, sputum samples were collected for further testing. In addition, 150 residents had their blood pressure checked, 130 were tested for blood sugar levels, and 110 underwent haemoglobin test-

ing, ensuring a comprehensive health check-up.

Medical teams from the District TB Centre, Moti Nagar, along with doctors and staff from the dispensary and State TB Cell, participated in the initiative.

To support patients, nutritional food baskets were distributed to 10 TB patients, emphasising the role of proper diet in recovery. A street play was also organised to spread awareness about TB symptoms, prevention, and treatment.

Health Department says outreach will continue to ensure accessible care and advance TB elimination goal. **MPST**

Bulandshahr: 2019-batch IAS officer appointed BKDA Vice-Chairperson



DIPIKA KIROLA

BULANDSHAHR: Dr Aparajita Singh Sinsinwar, a 2019 batch IAS officer, on Monday assumed charge as the new vice-chairperson of the Bulandshahr-Khurja Development Authority (BKDA).

She was welcomed by officials and staff members of the authority upon her arrival. Soon after taking charge, Sinsinwar reviewed ongoing projects and sought detailed information about various development schemes being executed in the region.

Emphasising her priorities, she directed officials to ensure planned and systematic development across the authority’s jurisdiction. She also stressed the need for prompt execution of works related to public welfare and improving civic amenities for residents.

“The focus should be on ensuring better infrastructure, transparency in functioning, and timely completion of proj-

The Bulandshahr-Khurja Dev Authority is responsible for urban planning, infra dev in the region

ects,” she told officials during the initial review meeting.

Before this posting, Sinsinwar was serving as the chief development officer (CDO) in Shahjahanpur district, where she was associated with several administrative and development initiatives.

Officials said her experience in handling development projects is expected to give a fresh push to ongoing and upcoming schemes under the authority.

The Bulandshahr-Khurja Development Authority is responsible for urban planning and infrastructure development in the region, including housing projects, road networks, and public utilities

Police ramps up ‘Nasha – Not Cool’ drive with campus, cinema visibility

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police’s week-long anti-drug campaign, “Nasha – Not Cool”, gathered pace on Day Four with targeted outreach at key youth hubs, including the North and South campuses of Delhi University and Connaught Place.

As part of an innovative approach, specially designed cut-outs carrying anti-drug messages were placed in public spaces. When picked up, they revealed messages discouraging substance abuse. Reactions from members of the public were recorded and are being shared on social

media to widen the campaign’s reach.

The materials prominently featured the MANAS National Narcotics Helpline (1933), a 24x7 toll-free service encouraging people to seek help and report drug-related concerns.

To enhance visibility, a rap-based theme song is being screened during Indian Premier League matches at Arun Jaitley Stadium as well as in cinema halls across the city. The campaign has received support from public figures, including Kumar Sanu, Anil Kapoor, Kamal Khan and Virender Sehwal. **MPST**

DELHI TO STANDARDISE 1,943 PDS SHOPS

CM: Weekly ration grievance camps from May 1, strict checks on dealers

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday announced a series of reforms in the food and public distribution system, including weekly grievance camps, strict action against erring ration dealers, and a push to provide free LPG connections to all eligible families by Diwali.

Chairing a high-level review meeting of the Food, Supplies and Consumer Affairs Department, the Chief Minister said, “Jan Shikayat Samadhan Camps will be held every Saturday from May 1, between 9 am and 11 am, at all designated centres, where ration card-related grievances will be resolved on the spot.” She added that Assistant Commis-

sioners will be present to ensure accountability and warned of surprise inspections to check proper implementation.

Emphasising transparency, Gupta directed strict action against irregularities such as under-weighting and unauthorized deductions. “Clear responsibility must be fixed on both dealers and suppliers, with stringent action against those found guilty,” she said.

The Chief Minister also announced plans to introduce

smart ration cards with QR codes to make the system more user-friendly. She instructed officials to standardise all 1,943 PDS shops, ensuring hygiene, uniform information boards, and improved service quality.

Reviewing the Free LPG Scheme, Gupta said the government aims to cover all eligible beneficiaries by Diwali. “All remaining eligible families must be covered, and a special registration drive should be conducted to expand Ujjwala connections,” she said, stressing the need for data sharing and Aadhaar-based e-KYC.

CM stresses benefits must reach every eligible person efficiently, transparently, and with dignity. **MPST**

Centre asks states to step up fire safety in healthcare facilities

CLARIFICATION BY EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTRY

Mideast conflict behind lack of consensus at Delhi BRICS meet

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India recently chaired a meeting of BRICS Deputy Foreign Ministers and Special Envoys on the Middle East and North Africa (BRICS MENA) in New Delhi, with the Ministry of External Affairs on Monday saying that a consensus could not be reached as there were differences on account of the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

The current conflict in West Asia began on February 28 when the US-Israeli combine launched military strikes on Iran, and Tehran retaliated by attacking Gulf states hosting US bases.

At an inter-ministerial briefing here on the West Asia situation, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal was asked what India's position is on the Palestine issue, given some reports claiming that New Delhi apparently 'diluted' its long-standing position on Palestine during the BRICS meeting held last week, which may have led to a lack of consensus.

"Let me clarify the issue for you... We have seen some speculative and inaccurate reporting on the recent BRICS officials' meeting," Jaiswal told reporters.

The MEA spokesperson urged reporters to refer to the joint statement released on the occasion of the India Arab League Foreign Ministers meeting earlier this year. "This meeting happened in Delhi. This outcome was endorsed by all



Ministry of External Affairs Secretary (South) Neena Malhotra poses for a group photograph during the BRICS MENA meeting, in New Delhi on April 24

HIGHLIGHTS

- » India recently chaired a meeting of BRICS Deputy Foreign Ministers and Special Envoys on the Middle East and North Africa (BRICS MENA) in New Delhi
- » The MEA said that a consensus could not be reached as there were differences on account of the ongoing conflict in

West Asia

- » The current conflict in West Asia began on February 28 when the US-Israeli combine launched military strikes on Iran
- » "We have seen some speculative and inaccurate reporting on the recent BRICS officials' meeting," MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said

issued after the meeting, as a joint statement "could not be reached", Jaiswal said at the briefing.

India is the current chair of the BRICS grouping.

Official sources on Sunday had said that sharp differences among the BRICS member states over the US-Israel war on Iran stalled India's efforts to build a consensus position on the conflict during the BRICS MENA meeting here last week.

There was no change in India's position on the Palestine issue at all, they had said.

As consensus on the West Asia conflict eluded, a "chair's statement" was released at the end of the deliberations.

During the BRICS MENA meeting, the participants expressed "deep concern" about the situation in the Middle East and also discussed the Palestine issue and the Gaza situation, the MEA had said on Friday.

Maha minister Nitesh Rane gets 1 month jail in 'mud pouring' case

MUMBAI: A court in Sindhudurg on Monday convicted Maharashtra minister Nitesh Rane in a 2019 case of pouring mud on an NHAI engineer when he was in Opposition, and sentenced him to one-month imprisonment, noting that lawmakers are not supposed to take the law into their hands.

Later, the court suspended Rane's sentence, allowing him time to appeal before a higher court, while acquitting 29 other accused in the case. "Even though Rane's intention was to raise a voice against the poor quality of work and inconvenience faced by the people, he was not supposed to humiliate or insult a public servant in public," additional sessions court judge V S Deshmukh stated.

"If such incidents continue to occur, public servants would not be able to discharge their duties with dignity," the judge noted. Calling the act "abuse of power," the court held that "it is the demand of time to curb such tendency".

Rane, a son of former Union

'Lawmakers are not supposed to take law into their hands'

minister Narayan Rane, was among 30 people charged under various offences, including rioting, assault to deter a public servant, and criminal conspiracy. He was in Congress when the incident occurred.

All the accused, including Nitesh Rane, were acquitted of these offences, as the court found insufficient evidence to support most of these claims.

However, the court found Nitesh Rane guilty of an offence under section 504 (intentional insult meant to provoke a breach of public peace) and sentenced him to one month's jail.

Rane, then a Congress MLA, had called the Sub-Divisional Engineer of the National Highway Authority, Prakash Shedgekar, to a bridge over the Gad river in Kankavli on July 4, 2019, for inspecting the work to widen the Mumbai-Goa Highway. MPOST

way for ending the Israeli military offensive in Gaza. The summit culminated in the conclusion of a ceasefire agreement in Gaza.

Jaiswal added that "differences at the recent BRICS meeting were on account of the ongoing conflict in West Asia".

A "chair summary" was

Cong boycotts Haryana Assembly's Special Session; Saini slams Oppn

CHANDIGARH: The Congress on Monday "boycotted" a special session of the Haryana Assembly, claiming that the issue of women's reservation that the government wanted to take up through a resolution did not fall under the purview of the House and accusing the ruling BJP of using the platform for vested political agenda and propaganda.

The Congress said the BJP, through a resolution, wanted to condemn the INDIA opposition bloc for the defeat of a Constitution amendment bill in the Lok Sabha.

Leader of Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda told reporters that the Congress Legislature Party in Haryana decided to boycott the special daylong Assembly session.

Hooda also claimed that the matter that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government wanted to discuss did not fall within the Assembly's jurisdiction.

The Opposition party later held a mock assembly session outside the Vidhan Sabha building.

Chief Minister Nayab Singh



Saini slammed the Congress, saying by boycotting the special session and holding a mock session at the parking lot of the Assembly, the party had disrespected the House.

He said such actions amount to disrespect towards the Assembly, democratic values and the dignity of women.

Clarifying the intent of the resolution that he moved in the Assembly, the chief minister said it was not political in nature and did not include the word "condemnation". He said the resolution was dedicated to the dignity, rights and empowerment of women.

The resolution was passed by a voice vote in the absence of

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Former Union minister Dinesh Trivedi was appointed India's next High Commissioner to Bangladesh on Monday amid efforts by the two countries to repair frayed bilateral ties.

He is expected to take up the assignment shortly, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said in a brief statement.

New Delhi's decision to send a seasoned politician to Dhaka comes at a time when both sides are looking to rebuild relations that came under severe strain during the tenure of Bangladesh's interim government headed by Muhammad Yunus.

A veteran politician from West Bengal, 75-year-old Trivedi held key portfolios as Railway Minister and Minister of State for Health during the UPA government.

AMID EFFORTS TO RESET TIES

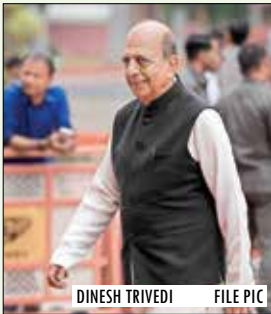
Former Union minister Dinesh Trivedi appointed India's next envoy to B'desh

INSIGHT

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DINESH TRIVEDI FILE PIC

the UPA government

» Having represented the state in the Rajya Sabha and as the Lok Sabha MP for Barrackpore, he resigned from the Trinamool Congress in February 2021 and subsequently joined the BJP

Having represented the state in the Rajya Sabha and as the Lok Sabha MP for Barrackpore,

he resigned from the Trinamool Congress in February 2021 and subsequently joined the BJP.

Nominations open for Padma Awards

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Citizens can file nominations and recommendations for the Padma Awards to be announced on Republic Day, 2027, by July 31 this year, a government statement said Monday.

The suggestions will only be received online on the Rashtriya Puraskar Portal (https://awards.gov.in), it said.

The civilian honours -- Padma Vibhushan, Padma Bhushan and Padma Shri -- are amongst the highest awards of the country.

The civilian honours are announced on Republic Day every year

Instituted in 1954, the civilian honours are announced on the Republic Day every year.

"The awards seek to recognize 'work of distinction' and is given for distinguished and exceptional achievements/service in all fields/disciplines, such as, Art, Literature and Education, Sports, Medicine, Social

Work, Science and Engineering, Public Affairs, Civil Service, Trade and Industry etc," the statement said.

There is no distinction of race, occupation, position, or sex to be eligible for these awards.

Government servants, except doctors and scientists, are not eligible for Padma Awards.

"The government is committed to transform Padma Awards into 'People's Padma'. All citizens are, therefore, requested to make nominations/recommendations, including self nomination," it said.

Trivedi holds an MBA degree from the University of Texas, Austin.

He will succeed Pranay Verma, who has been appointed as New Delhi's next ambassador to Belgium and the European Union (EU).

The relations between India and Bangladesh witnessed a major downturn after the Yunus-led interim government came to power following the collapse of the Sheikh Hasina government in August, 2024.

Verma played a role in initiating the efforts to reset the ties after the new Bangladesh Nationalist Party government led by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman came to power in February.

Earlier this month, Bangladesh's Foreign Minister Khaliur Rahman visited India and held talks with National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar.

Sanjay Dutt apologises over 'Sarke Chunar' row



Sanjay Dutt arrives at the NCW office in New Delhi

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Actor Sanjay Dutt on Monday appeared before the National Commission for Women (NCW) over the controversy surrounding the song 'Sarke Chunar Teri Sarka' and submitted a written apology, expressing regret for any "unintended" harm caused.

The hearing, led by NCW chairperson Vijaya Rahatkar, flagged concerns over alleged vulgarity and the indecent portrayal of women in the song from the film KD The Devil. The commission questioned issues of intent, awareness and accountability, stressing whether adequate due diligence was undertaken before associating with content that could be seen as objectifying women.

Highlighting the responsibility of influential public figures, the NCW underscored the need for adherence to legal and societal standards. As a corrective step, Dutt committed to sponsoring the education of 50 tribal girls to support social welfare and women's empowerment. He also assured that future contracts would include mandatory legal checks to ensure dignified representation.

Actor Nora Fatehi, also summoned, could not appear and has sought a new date.

Earlier, Leh and Kargil were the only two districts in Ladakh

2.74 lakh, according to the 2011 census.

"The development is aligned with Honourable Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of a developed and prosperous Ladakh," Saxena said in the post.

The L-G added that this "transformative decision, already approved by the Ministry of Home Affairs in August 2024, under the leadership of Minister of Home Affairs Amit Shah, would strengthen grassroots governance, decentralise administration & ensure faster delivery of public services to the people of Ladakh, especially those in remote and far-flung areas".

"Creation of new districts, apart from bringing governance closer to citizens, will create new avenues for growth, employment and entrepreneurship," the Ladakh LG added.

MPOST BUREAU

LEH/JAMMU: Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Monday approved the creation of five new districts in the Union Territory, fulfilling the aspirations and long-pending demand of the people of the region.

He termed the decision a "historic day" for Ladakh.

"I have approved the notification for the creation of five new districts in Ladakh, fulfilling the aspirations and long-pending demand of the people of Ladakh," the LG said in a post on X.

Saxena said that with the creation of five new districts -- Nubra, Sham, Changthang, Zaskar and Drass -- Ladakh will now have seven districts, taking the total number of districts in the Union Territory to seven.

Earlier, Leh and Kargil were the only two districts in Ladakh, the largest Union Territory in terms of area but the second least populous. It has an expanse of 86,904 square kilometres bordering China and Pakistan, with a population of

Rlys invite entries for travelogue contest

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Railways has launched the "Rail Yatra Vritant Puraskar Yojna" to invite rail travel experiences from the public and railway employees, aiming to improve passenger facilities and promote the use of Hindi.

Participants are required to submit original travelogues in Hindi, based on their rail journeys. Entries must be between 3,000 and 3,500 words, typed in double spacing with proper formatting, and include personal details on the first page.

Winners will receive cash prizes and citations, with the first prize set at Rs 10,000, second at Rs 8,000 and third at Rs 6,000. Five consolation prizes of Rs 4,000 each will also be awarded.

Government employees must declare that no vigilance or disciplinary cases are pending against them, while other participants must confirm they are not facing any criminal proceedings. All entrants must certify that their submissions are original and have not been awarded elsewhere. MPOST

Punjab CM reviews flood preparedness

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Monday reviewed the state's flood preparedness and approved the purchase of advanced amphibious machines to strengthen state's flood prevention and relief infrastructure.

He asserted that the state government is moving proactively to minimise damage and protect lives ahead of the monsoon season.

Chairing a high-level meeting here, Mann said: "In order to carry out flood relief measures further in a smooth and hassle free manner, consent has been given to purchase amphibious machines for desilting of rivers and drains effectively."

He emphasised that these machines are capable of operating even in running water and can carry out deep desilting, making them critical for both preventive action and emergency response.

"These multipurpose machines can carry on desilting deeply due to which acquiring them is the need of the hour to carry flood relief operations both in anticipation and in case of emergency," he stated, while directing the department

He approved the purchase of advanced amphibious machines

to prepare a detailed blueprint for their procurement.

Referring to global best practices, Mann said, "I had seen the operations of this machine recently during my trip to Finland where these multipurpose machines are optimally utilized."

He added that these machines can be effectively deployed for maintenance and cleaning of rivers, drains, ponds and other water bodies, alongside flood protection works.

"The acquisition of these machines by the state government will go a long way in mitigating the woes faced by people due to fury of floods," he noted. Highlighting water management concerns, Mann said, "The maximum water level of the Bhakra Dam was 1,680 feet and on April 26 this was recorded as 1,594 feet."

He stressed that with paddy sowing set to begin from June 1, water release must be planned carefully in view of the approaching monsoon. MPOST

MCF Raebareli participates in INCOMEX 2026



RAEBARELI: Modern Coach Factory (MCF), Raebareli, is participating in the industrial exhibition INCOMEX-2026, being held from April 25 to 29 by the Karnataka Chamber of Commerce and Industry (KCCI), in line with directives of the Railway Board.

The exhibition aims to strengthen coordination between the Railways and industry while showcasing technological advancements. MCF has set up a stall highlighting Vande Bharat coaches, LHB coach manufacturing, production capacity and new technologies. Since its inception, the factory has produced over 15,000 LHB coaches.

A "Railway Vendor Development Pavilion" is also facilitating industry participation, particularly MSMEs, by connecting them with business opportunities and the Railways' e-procurement system. MPOST



EDITORIAL
NO OVERREACH
IN BAIL

The Supreme Court of India has, in a succinct yet significant observation, reaffirmed a foundational principle of criminal jurisprudence: judicial authority must operate strictly within the contours of law. In ruling that a court, while rejecting anticipatory bail, cannot direct an accused to surrender before a trial court, the apex court has drawn a crucial line between what is permissible judicial discretion and what amounts to jurisdictional overreach. At a time when procedural safeguards are often tested by the pressures of docket management and public sentiment, this clarification is both timely and necessary. The case before the bench comprising Justices J B Pardiwala and Ujjal Bhuyan arose from a fairly routine criminal matter involving allegations of cheating, forgery and related offences stemming from a land dispute. The Jharkhand High Court had rejected the accused's anticipatory bail plea, noting the absence of any new circumstances since an earlier rejection. However, it went a step further—directing the accused to surrender before the trial court and seek regular bail, relying on the precedent set in Satender Kumar Antil v. CBI. It is this additional directive that drew the Supreme Court's disapproval.

At the heart of the matter lies the delicate balance between judicial discretion and statutory limits. Anticipatory bail, as envisaged under Section 438 of the Code of Criminal Procedure, is a pre-arrest legal remedy designed to protect individuals from arbitrary or motivated arrests. When a court rejects such a plea, it essentially declines to extend this protective shield. However, the rejection does not, by itself, create a legal obligation for the accused to surrender. The Supreme Court's ruling underscores that while courts are empowered to adjudicate on bail applications, they cannot impose conditions or directions that the law itself does not authorise. This distinction is not merely technical—it goes to the core of personal liberty. The power to compel surrender carries significant consequences, including the immediate loss of liberty and the psychological weight of custodial processes. By asserting that such a direction falls outside judicial jurisdiction in the context of anticipatory bail, the Supreme Court has reinforced the principle that liberty cannot be curtailed except through procedures established by law. In doing so, it has upheld the spirit of Article 21 of the Constitution, which guarantees that no person shall be deprived of life or personal liberty except according to due process.

The reliance by the High Court on the Satender Kumar Antil judgment also merits scrutiny. That landmark ruling was intended to streamline arrest and bail procedures, particularly to reduce unnecessary incarceration and promote a more rational approach to custody. It emphasised that arrests should not be routine and that bail should be the norm rather than the exception in many categories of offences. However, as the Supreme Court's latest observation makes clear, precedents must be applied in their proper context. Extending their interpretation beyond what they explicitly authorise risks distorting their purpose. There is, in this episode, a broader institutional message. Courts, especially at the high court level, often operate under immense pressure—managing heavy caseloads, responding to public expectations, and navigating complex legal questions. In such an environment, there may be a temptation to adopt pragmatic shortcuts, such as directing an accused to surrender to expedite proceedings. Yet, as the Supreme Court has reminded, procedural convenience cannot override legal propriety. The rule of law demands not only that justice be done, but that it be done strictly in accordance with established legal frameworks.

Equally important is the signal this judgment sends to litigants and the legal community. It reinforces the idea that remedies available under law must be clearly distinguished and independently exercised. Anticipatory bail and regular bail serve different purposes and operate at different stages of the criminal process. Conflating the two—by effectively forcing an accused to transition from one to the other through judicial direction—undermines this carefully constructed legal architecture. The Supreme Court's intervention thus restores conceptual clarity and procedural integrity. The implications of this ruling extend beyond the immediate facts of the case. It is a reminder that judicial orders must remain anchored in jurisdictional competence. Overreach, even when well-intentioned, can erode confidence in the legal system and create precedents that blur the boundaries of authority. In a constitutional democracy, where the separation of powers and adherence to procedure are foundational, such clarity is indispensable. At a deeper level, the judgment reaffirms the judiciary's role as the guardian of individual rights. In recent years, concerns have been raised about the inconsistent application of bail principles and the prolonged incarceration of undertrial prisoners. Against this backdrop, the Supreme Court's insistence on respecting legal limits assumes added significance. It signals a continued commitment to ensuring that the criminal justice system does not become punitive at the pre-trial stage.

Ultimately, this ruling is less about a single procedural question and more about reaffirming a constitutional ethos. It reiterates that the exercise of judicial power must be disciplined by law, not driven by expediency. By correcting the jurisdictional misstep of the High Court, the Supreme Court has not only provided relief in an individual case but also strengthened the broader framework within which justice is administered. In a system where liberty and authority must coexist in careful balance, such interventions serve as essential course corrections. They remind us that the legitimacy of the judiciary rests not just on its outcomes, but on its fidelity to the law. And in that fidelity lies the true strength of India's constitutional order.

POLITICAL
FLUX



JOHN FELIX RAJ &
PRABHAT KUMAR DATTA

FELIX RAJ IS THE
VICE CHANCELLOR,
PRABHAT
KUMAR DATTA
IS AN ADJUNCT
PROFESSOR, BOTH
AT ST. XAVIER'S
UNIVERSITY,
KOLKATA

The latest round
of political
defections is
not an isolated
rupture but part
of a deeper
structural churn

New Wave of Bulk Defections

Mass defections and shifting loyalties expose cracks in India's political morality, raising urgent questions about mandate integrity, governance stability and the limits of law

Recent political tremors, now exemplified by the defection of Raghav Chadha along with six other MPs to the Bharatiya Janata Party, underline a deepening churn in Indian politics. This is no longer speculative drift but a decisive realignment that has altered the balance in the Rajya Sabha and exposed the fragility of party cohesion. The episode mirrors earlier high-profile political reconfigurations involving the Shiv Sena and Nationalist Congress Party in Maharashtra, the Bahujan Samaj Party in Rajasthan, and the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen in Bihar. In these instances, the pursuit of power routinely overshadows ideological consistency. When political morality is subordinated to expediency, governance risks becoming transactional, weakening institutional credibility, distorting mandates, and eroding public trust—ultimately diverting attention from long-term developmental priorities that require stability, accountability, and principled leadership.

Global Perspective on "Crossing the Floor"
The practice of switching loyalties is not unique to India. In the British House of Commons, "crossing the floor" is historically viewed as an act of disloyalty, yet the annals of history include titans like Winston Churchill, Ramsay MacDonald, and William Gladstone, who famously navigated shifting party lines. Similarly, swapping loyalties has surfaced in the democratic frameworks of the USA, Australia, and Canada, proving that the tension between personal conviction and party discipline is a universal democratic challenge.
Defection and the Erosion of Stability
Defection is fundamentally a betrayal of the voter's mandate. It acts as a destabilising force that can topple popular administrations overnight. History provides stark examples: the governments of Sri Lanka collapsed due to defections in both 1964 and 2001. When legislators treat their allegiance



Raghav Chadha's defection highlights the fragility of party loyalty in contemporary politics

as a tradable commodity, the structural integrity of the state begins to crumble.
Accountability vs Party Lines
The Westminster model demands that elected representatives remain accountable to the electorate. Elections are not merely procedural formalities; they are the expression of the collective will. However, some framers of the Indian Constitution, such as K.T. Shah and Shibban Lal Saxena, warned that party interests might eventually outweigh principled governance. They feared that executive positions would be distributed based on party loyalty rather than merit—a concern that remains valid today, as the original constitutional text remained silent on intra-party relationships.
From Independence to "Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram"
Political defection in India is not a post-independence novelty. Figures like Shyam Lal Nehru and Hafiz Moham-med Ibrahim switched sides during the British era. However, the crisis peaked in the 1960s following the decline of the "Congress System." The year 1967 saw a Haryana legislator change parties

thrice in a single day, immortalising the phrase "Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram."
Between 1967 and 1983, approximately 2,700 cases of defection were recorded in State Assemblies. The allure of office was undeniable: 116 out of 210 defecting legislators during this period were rewarded with positions in the Council of Ministers, cementing the link between defection and opportunism.
Governance Gap
The cost of defection is often paid by the citizens. For example, when 22 MLAs in Madhya Pradesh resigned in 2020 to join the BJP, the state was left without a cabinet for nearly a month. This political vacuum occurred exactly as the COVID-19 pandemic began to surge, bringing essential governance to a halt at a time when the public needed leadership the most.
Paradox of the 10th Schedule
To curb this menace, Parliament enacted the Anti-Defection Law (10th Schedule) via the 52nd Amendment in 1985. While intended to provide stability, the law contains a significant loophole: it exempts "mergers" involv-

ing two-thirds of a party's strength. A study by the Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy suggests that this has simply traded individual defections for "bulk defections," allowing parties to bypass the law's intent while maintaining legal cover.
The Path Forward: Law, Morality, and Reform
The Law Commission and the Second Administrative Reforms Commission (2007) have suggested that the power to disqualify members should rest with the President or Governor, acting on the advice of the Election Commission, rather than the Speaker.
However, experts like M.C. Setalvad and C.K. Daphtary argue that the solution is political, not just legal. In the US and UK, where no formal anti-defection laws exist, legislators often vote against their party (as seen during the impeachment proceedings of Donald Trump). In those systems, the "check" is internal party democracy and the judgment of the voters, rather than a rigid legal ban.
Gap Between Legality and Ethics
The persistence of political defection in India suggests that legal frameworks alone cannot safeguard democracy if political morality is absent. As James Madison famously noted in the *Federalist Papers*:
"If men were angels, no government would be necessary... In framing a government which is to be administered by men over men, the great difficulty lies in this: you must first enable the government to control the governed; and in the next place, oblige it to control itself."
For India to move beyond the cycle of opportunistic alliances, political parties must prioritise internal democracy and ideological integrity. Until the "lure of office" is replaced by a genuine commitment to the electorate, the "Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram" culture will continue to haunt the halls of power, regardless of the laws on the books.
Views expressed are personal

NATION
BUILDERS



PRABHU DAYAL

THE WRITER IS A
RETIRED INDIAN
DIPLOMAT AND
HAD PREVIOUSLY
SERVED AS CONSUL
GENERAL IN
NEW YORK

Industrialists
who combine
innovation,
scale and social
responsibility
are prominent
in India's rise,
making a
compelling case
for their inclusion
among the
nation's highest
honourees

Recognising Industrial Vanguards

As India's economy expands, the meaning of national service must include visionary entrepreneurs who build prosperity with responsibility

The Bharat Ratna, India's highest civilian honour, is conferred "in recognition of exceptional service/performance of the highest order" in any field of human endeavour. While traditionally associated with politicians, scientists, and artists, the expansion of the criteria in 2011 to include "any field" reflects a modern understanding of national contribution. Business and industry leaders are not merely profit-seekers; they are nation-builders who create the infrastructural, economic, and social framework that allows a country to prosper. Therefore, acknowledging outstanding industrial leaders with the Bharat Ratna is essential to recognize their extraordinary contributions to India's development.

Industry leaders are the architects of modern India's infrastructure and self-reliance. When J.R.D. Tata was awarded the Bharat Ratna in 1992, which was a recognition of his role in creating the country's first airline, its steel backbone, and its scientific institutions. Today's entrepreneurs continue this legacy by solving systemic challenges—from digitising the economy to placing India on the global map of innovation. By building world-class companies, they provide the "economic fuel" that funds the country's social welfare programs and public projects.
Industrial leaders are the engines of the Indian economy. They drive the nation's GDP growth, foster innovation, and turn India into a global competitor. The liberalisation, privatisation, and globalisation (LPG) reforms of 1991 shifted India from a state-led industrial model to a market-led one, where private enterprises took the lead in economic transformation. Leaders in sectors such as Information Technology (IT), automotive, and pharmaceuticals have not only increased national income but also placed India on the global map as a tech capital and pharmacy of the world. Their capacity to create immense wealth and opportunities for the nation justifies their inclusion in the highest national recognitions.
Beyond financial figures, industrialists are critical in addressing the pressing issue of unemploy-



JRD Tata's legacy proves that wealth creation, when guided by values, can transform society and elevate business into a pillar of nation-building

ment. They establish manufacturing units and service sectors that provide employment to millions of skilled and semi-skilled workers, including in the crucial IT industry, which employs nearly 6 million people directly and indirectly. They also play a vital role in regional development, setting up industries in underdeveloped areas, thus contributing to a more balanced economic growth. This transformative impact on the livelihood of millions aligns directly with the "public service" aspect of the Bharat Ratna.
A key argument for recognising industrialists is their commitment to social welfare, which often extends far beyond business obligations. The Tata Group, for example, has set a benchmark for nation-building, with a significant portion of its profits directed towards social welfare, education, and healthcare through Tata Trusts. Leaders like JRD Tata—the only industrialist to receive the award so far—represented the pinnacle of integrity, humility, and dedication to the common man. Awarding such individuals honours the spirit of service, proving that success can be achieved with kindness and responsibility toward humanity.
Industrialists contribute to the nation's security and self-reliance by reducing dependence on imports. By building indigenous capabilities in steel, defense,

technology, and pharmaceuticals, these leaders help strengthen the country's economic and defense stability. They are instrumental in realising the 'Make in India' vision, attracting foreign investment while fostering indigenous innovation.
The Bharat Ratna represents the ultimate respect for exceptional service to the country. While politicians and social leaders have long been honoured, the role of business leaders in shaping modern India is just as profound. By creating jobs, driving the economy, fostering technological progress, and engaging in massive philanthropic efforts, outstanding industrial leaders are true "Jewels of India". Recognising their service is not only fitting but essential to inspire future generations to uphold ethical leadership and nation-building.
The definition of "service to the nation" must evolve with the times. Business and industry leaders who operate with integrity and vision are not merely seekers of profit; they are the engines of India's progress. As India transitions into a global economic powerhouse, there is a compelling case for more recognition of business and industry leaders. Bestowing the Bharat Ratna upon them would be a fitting tribute to the hands that build the nation's future.
Views expressed are personal

WHO SAID
WHAT

Preeti Choudhry
@PreetiChoudhry

My exit poll! As I leave #Bengal, it would be a disservice not to say this: I have come to deeply admire the way women inhabit space here. There is a quiet, almost subconscious elevation of women as independent beings . something that stands in stark contrast to the entrenched misogyny that still finds resonance across much of northern India. Perhaps it stems from a cultural understanding of shakti. A form of empowerment that manifests here in ways both subtle and profound, unlike anywhere else in the country, even in the south.
Any woman journalist who has covered political rallies across India will recognize the difference immediately. Other states, a crowd is not just a logistical challenge, it carries risk, the inevitability of wandering hands, the violation masked by chaos. Here, the crowds are no less dense, the air no less heavy with sweat and alcohol—but the hands, for the most part, do not grope. Men step aside to make way. When contact happens, as it inevitably does in chaos, there is visible embarrassment rather than entitlement. What you encounter is not chivalry, but something far rarer: equality. And equality feels far more meaningful. Was never a fan of chivalry in any case :) There is more. Women politicians across party lines campaign with a striking freedom, aggressive, sharp, unapologetically irreverent, often using what would elsewhere be labelled as 'masculine' rhetoric. In most states, such behaviour would invite judgment, even censure. Here, it is met with acceptance, applause. What feels liberating to an outsider is, in Bengal, simply normal. What we frame as empowerment here is a cultural undercurrent.
I have covered four elections in this state, and each time I have returned with the same sense of awe. Bengal, meanwhile, ambles on with a certain bemusement, as if unaware of what sets it apart. But it is a big deal. And perhaps the most remarkable part is that Bengal does not think so. Governments will come and go. One can only hope that this constant endures, not just how Bengal sees its women, but how, in many ways, it doesn't.

PUTIN MEETS IRAN'S FM ARAGHCHI

Russia ready to do its best to help bring peace to West Asia: Putin

MOSCOW: Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Monday met Russian President Vladimir Putin, who hailed the Iranian people for fighting bravely and heroically for their sovereignty and said Moscow is ready to do its best to help bring peace to West Asia as soon as possible.

Araghchi, who held talks with Omani and Pakistani leadership before arriving in Russia, met Putin in St. Petersburg and thanked him for supporting Iran, state-owned TASS news agency reported.

"Russia is ready to do everything in its power to ensure that peace in the Middle East is achieved as soon as possible," Putin said during his meeting with Araghchi, which was also attended by Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov.

Revealing that he received a message from Iranian Supreme



Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi (left) and Russian President Vladimir Putin

Leader Mojtaba Khamenei last week, Putin asked Araghchi to convey his "gratitude for this message and best wishes for his health and well-being."

He praised the Iranian people for fighting "bravely and heroically" for their sovereignty, Iran's state-run PRESS

TV reported.

"We really hope that, based on the courage and desire for independence, the Iranian people, under the guidance of the new leader, will weather this difficult period of trials and peace will come," Putin said.

Highlights

» Araghchi said relations between Moscow and Tehran represent a 'strategic partnership at the highest level'

» Araghchi arrived at St. Petersburg's Pulkovo Airport early Monday

» Araghchi said that the world witnessed Iran's strength in countering the United States

He also stressed that Russia "intends to maintain" its strategic relations with Iran.

Araghchi said that the world witnessed Iran's strength in countering the US during the recent war, wand that the Islamic Republic is a "stable and powerful establishment."

"With their courage, the Iranian people succeeded in resisting the US aggression and will be able to endure it," he said.

He said that it became clear that Iran has "great friends and allies" like Russia, and conveyed "warmest greetings" from Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei and President Masoud Peshkian to the Russian leader.

Araghchi said relations between Moscow and Tehran represent a "strategic partnership at the highest level" and will continue to develop "regardless of circumstances." "We are grateful to you for the solid and strong positions in support of the Islamic Republic of Iran," he said. Foreign Minister Lavrov said that the talks between President Putin and the Iranian Foreign Minister were "useful and constructive."

AGENCIES

Hafiz Saeed's close aide Sheikh Yousaf Afridi shot dead in Pak

Over a week ago in Lahore, Amir Hamza, a founding leader of LeT, suffered bullet injuries in an attack

LAHORE: Sheikh Yousaf Afridi, a key Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) figure and a close associate of the Mumbai terror attack mastermind Hafiz Saeed, was shot dead by unidentified gunmen in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, police said on Monday. The incident took place in Landi Kotal in the Khyber region, some 250 kms from Islamabad, the capital of Pakistan. A source in the police told PTI that unknown armed assailants opened indiscriminate fire on Afridi, resulting in his death on the spot. No group has claimed responsibility for the attack.

Afridi is said to be a key figure within the regional structure of the banned LeT.

He also reportedly played a role in the recruitment and coordination of the terror group's activities in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. "The incident has sparked widespread anger

Key Points

» The incident took place in Landi Kotal in the Khyber region

» No group has claimed responsibility for attack

» Afridi is said to be a key figure within the regional structure of the banned LeT

» The incident has sparked widespread anger in area, and local authorities have launched a probe to apprehend those responsible for his killing'

in the area, and local authorities have launched an investigation to apprehend those responsible for his killing," the source said. An official

of Saeed's banned Jamat-ud-Dawa (JuD) said that Afridi was a "renowned religious scholar and belonged to the Zakhkhel tribe of Khyber and was regarded as a prominent scholar of the Ahl-e-Hadith (Salafi) school of thought."

"He was targeted when unidentified attackers sprayed him with bullets and managed to flee the scene.

It should be remembered that extremist groups like -- Khawarij (Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan) -- are currently facing strong intellectual and practical challenges from Salafi scholars," he said. Over a week ago in Lahore, Amir Hamza, a founding leader of LeT, suffered bullet injuries in an attack.

Hamza is LeT's second most important leader after Saeed, who has been in Lahore's Kot Lakhpat Jail since 2019 after getting convicted for several years in terror financing cases.

AGENCIES

King Charles III arrives in US, aims to ease strained ties



A rift between the UK government and Trump over issues including the Iran war had already raised the political stakes

WASHINGTON: Two and a half centuries after the American colonies declared independence from Britain under King George III, his descendant King Charles III lands in Washington Monday with trans-Atlantic ties under strain and security in the spotlight.

A shooting at a Washington dinner attended by President Donald Trump on Saturday sparked a last-minute security review of the four-day state visit, intended to celebrate the United States' 250th anniversary, and the US-UK "special relationship."

Buckingham Palace said the king "is greatly relieved to hear that the president, first lady and all guests have been unharmed." After a security review, the palace said the trip "will proceed as planned."

A rift between the UK

A leaked Pentagon email suggested the US could reassess support for the UK's sovereignty over the Falkland Islands in south Atlantic

government and Trump over issues including the Iran war had already raised the political stakes for the British monarch's visit.

In recent weeks, Trump has lambasted Prime Minister Keir Starmer over his unwillingness to join US military attacks on Iran, dismissing Britain's leader as "not Winston Churchill" — the World War II prime minister who coined the phrase "special relationship" for the UK-US bond.

AGENCIES

'At least 42 people killed in Chad during clashes over water resources'

N'DJAMENA: At least 42 people were killed in eastern Chad after a clash between two families over a water point escalated into a cycle of reprisals, the country's deputy prime minister said late Sunday. Limane Mahamat said during a visit to the village of Igote, in the Wadi Fira province, near the border with Sudan, where the clashes occurred on Saturday, that 42 people were killed and 10 wounded. He said those injured were evacuated to the provincial health centre.

Mahamat said the cycle of reprisals had spread over a fairly large area, prompting an intervention by the army. He said the "swift response" by the military helped contain the clashes and that the situation is now "under control."

The deputy prime minister announced the launch of a 'customary mediation' process in the village and of judicial proceedings to determine criminal responsibility.

Intercommunal clashes over resources are common in the Central African country. Last year, clashes between farmers and herders in south-western Chad left 42 people dead and several homes burned.

Mahamat said the government will take "all necessary measures" to prevent a destabilisation of the border area. Chad's eastern provinces have for several months been hosting refugees fleeing the war in Sudan.

AGENCIES

Russian attack injures 14 while Ukrainian drones kill two people in Russia-held area

KYIV: A Russian drone attack before dawn on Ukraine's southern city of Odesa wounded 14 people, including two children, authorities said Monday, in the latest barrage of civilian areas that have been a hallmark of Moscow's full-scale invasion.

Meanwhile, a Ukrainian drone strike killed two people in the Russia-occupied part of Ukraine's southern Kherson region, Moscow-installed Gov Vladimir Saldo said Monday. A man and a woman in their 70s died in the village of Dniptyrny, he said.

In Odesa, drones hit residential neighbourhoods and civilian infrastructure, said Serhii Lysak, the head of the city's administration. Russia has repeatedly targeted Odesa, a key Black Sea port for Ukraine, since Moscow launched the war more than four years ago on Feb 24, 2022.

Five of the wounded, most of them with shrapnel



An injured man stands inside the yard of a residential house destroyed by a Russian strike on Odesa

AP/PTI

“UKRAINE HAS RECENTLY BEEN HELPING MIDDLE EASTERN AND GULF REGION NATIONS”

wounds, were hospitalized, according to Oleh Kiper, the

head of the regional military administration.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Monday that Russia has fired approximately 1,900 attack drones, nearly 1,400 powerful guided aerial bombs and around 60 missiles of various types at Ukraine over the past week.

HISTORIC ENCOUNTER

Pope prays with Archbishop of Canterbury Sarah Mullally



been unthinkable just a few years ago, given the divisions between their two churches

over women's ordination and Mullally's appointment.

Leo acknowledged that

"new problems" in their relationship had been added onto "historically divisive issues". But he nevertheless vowed to continue the tradition of past popes to continue to try to reunite the churches. Anglicans split from Rome in 1534, when English King Henry VIII was refused a marriage annulment. Despite a formal theological dialogue that began in the 1960s, big differences remain, especially over the Church of England's

decision to ordain women. The Roman Catholic Church reserves the priesthood for men. Leo quoted Pope Francis as telling Anglican primates that "it would be a scandal if, due to our divisions, we did not fulfil our common vocation to make Christ known." "For my part, I add that it would also be a scandal if we did not continue to work towards overcoming our differences, no matter how intractable they may appear," Leo said.

AGENCIES

Bahrain strips 69 people of citizenship

DUBAI: Bahrain revoked citizenship rights of 60 people for praising Iran's "hostile and criminal acts".

Bahrain's interior ministry said the move also applied to the families of individuals accused.

The ministry said it revoked citizenship rights "of those who expressed sympathy and praise for Iran's hostile and criminal acts".

Bahrain is among several countries in the region that tightly controlled information about Iranian strikes during the war, arresting residents and foreigners who filmed them.

The Sunni-ruled monarchy, like Iran, has a majority Shiite population and saw pro-Iran demonstrations early in the conflict.

Authorities arrested protesters and those who filmed demonstrations en masse, charging dozens with misusing social media, inciting hatred or treason, an offence that can carry the death penalty.

AGENCIES

Energy shock ripples through kitchens, forests & conservation in Africa, South Asia

Rising demand for biomass fuels also degrades watersheds and wildlife habitats

NAIROBI: Before sunset, a blue flame used to spring to life in Brenda Obar's kitchen with a quick turn of the knob as she started dinner.

Now, her stove is often cold as she crouches over a charcoal burner, coaxing a smoky fire to cook for her family outside her tin-roofed home in Kibera in Kenya's capital Nairobi, one of Africa's largest informal settlements. Cooking gas is too expensive and often unavailable. Charcoal is always there.

"We don't have many options," she said. "You use what you can afford."

Stories like hers are becoming more common because of the energy disruptions caused by the Iran war. Governments had promoted cleaner fuels like LPG for health and conservation reasons, but rising costs are undermining those gains.

The impacts are spreading beyond gas pumps to kitchens, forests, and wildlife habitats. Across Africa and South Asia, governments have spent years trying to shift households away from burning charcoal and fire-



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

wood to cleaner fuels like liquefied petroleum gas, or LPG.

That push was driven by concerns over risks from air pollution, which killed 2.9 million people in 2021, according to the World Health Organisation. But it also was focused on conservation, since use of firewood or charcoal increases pressure on forests and wildlife. Cutting trees faster than they grow back accelerates deforestation.

As more people search

for fuel in the forest, they are encountering wildlife. At the same time, economic pressures can drive more poaching and bushmeat hunting, increasing the chance of diseases spreading from animals to people. Falling tourism means less funding for conservation, while high fuel costs make it harder for field teams to operate and respond quickly when wild animals enter human areas.

"The longer this debacle runs, the harder it is going to

Takeaways

» As more people search for fuel in forest, they are encountering wildlife

» Falling tourism means less funding for conservation

» Cooking gas is too expensive and often unavailable in Nairobi

hit conservation," said Mayukh Chatterjee, the International Union for Conservation of Nature's co-chair for its conflict and co-existence specialist group.

When LPG, kerosene or electricity become too expensive or unreliable, many families turn to firewood and charcoal because they are easier to get in cash-poor settings, even though they harm the environment, said Paula Kahumbu, a wildlife conservationist, and CEO of Nairobi-based WildlifeDirect.

"The first conservation risk

from an energy shock in Africa is not abstract. It is household fuel switching," she said.

Rising demand for biomass fuels also degrades watersheds and wildlife habitats as people go deeper into previously undisturbed areas, increasing pressure on ecosystems and the species that depend on them.

Experts fear that rising diesel prices and higher fertilizer costs will also hurt farm productivity, reducing yields and increasing food insecurity.

"The crisis is impacting more than forests," Kahumbu said. Charcoal, made by slowly burning wood in kilns, is one of the most widely used cooking fuels in sub-Saharan Africa and a major driver of deforestation. Demand is climbing among customers in Nairobi's low-income settlements, according to charcoal seller Munyao Kithaka. A similar shift is underway in India, the world's second-largest LNG importer, with about 60 per cent of its supply coming from the Gulf region, according to S&P Global.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

PLANE CRASHES ON OUTSKIRTS OF SOUTH SUDAN'S CAPITAL, 14 KILLED

JUBA: A Cessna aircraft crashed Monday on the outskirts of the South Sudanese capital, killing all 13 passengers and the pilot, the country's civil aviation authority said. The authority said preliminary reports indicate that the plane may have crashed due to adverse weather conditions that caused poor visibility. Among those onboard were two Kenyan nationals, while the rest were South Sudanese, officials said. The civil aviation authority said a team had been dispatched to the site, about 20 kilometers (12 miles) outside Juba, to gather information and support emergency services.

PAK SECURITY FORCES FOIL INFILTRATION BID BY TALIBAN MILITANTS, 3 INJURED

PESHAWAR: Three civilians, including two women, were injured on Monday in alleged cross-border firing by Afghan Taliban forces, after Pakistan's security forces foiled an infiltration bid by militants along the border in South Waziristan, a security official said. Pakistani troops repelled an infiltration attempt by Taliban militants along the Pak-Afghan border in the Angoor Adda Zulul Khel area, the official said. Pakistan forces attributed the failed attempt to militants referred to as "Fitna al-Khawarij". Fitna al-Khawarij is a term used by the state for terrorists belonging to the outlawed Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP). In response to the infiltration attempt, security forces reportedly destroyed multiple Afghan checkpoints.

Suspect in Washington dinner shooting set to appear in court

Cole Tomas Allen will face charges including assault on a federal officer and using a firearm during a crime of violence

WASHINGTON: The man who authorities say tried to storm the White House Correspondents' Association dinner with guns and knives while President Donald Trump was in attendance is due in court Monday to face charges in a chaotic encounter that resulted in shots being fired, Trump being rushed off the stage and guests ducking for cover underneath their tables.

Cole Tomas Allen was taken into custody after the shooting on Saturday night and is being charged in federal

court in Washington.

Court papers laying out the charges were not immediately available, though authorities have said Allen will face charges including assault on a federal officer and using a firearm during a crime of violence.

Authorities say an officer wearing a bullet-resistant vest was shot in the vest but is expected to recover.

It was unclear if Allen, of Torrance, California, had a lawyer who could speak on his behalf. The Associated Press called multiple phone num-



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

bers listed for Allen and relatives in public records, and

there was no answer when a reporter knocked on the door

Highlights

- » Suspect Allen was taken into custody after the shooting on Saturday
- » Court papers laying out the charges were not immediately available
- » It was unclear if Allen, of Torrance, California, had a lawyer who could speak on his behalf

of his home. Prosecutors have not revealed a motive, but in a message reviewed by the AP that authorities say was sent by Allen to family members minutes before the attack,

Allen referred to himself as a "Friendly Federal Assassin," made repeated references to the Republican president without naming him and alluded to grievances over a range of

Trump administration actions.

Investigators are treating the writings, along with a trail of social media posts and interviews with family members, as some of the clearest evidence of the suspect's mindset and possible motives.

Allen, 31, is believed to have travelled by train from California to Chicago and then onto Washington, where he checked himself in as a guest at the hotel where the gala dinner was held with its typically tight security, acting Attorney General Todd Blanche said. Video posted

by Trump shows a man, who authorities say was armed with guns and knives, running past security barricade as Secret Service agents run toward him.

Records show Allen is a highly educated tutor and amateur video game developer.

A social media profile for a man with the same name and a photo that appears to match that of the suspect show he worked part-time for the last six years at a company that offers admissions counselling and test preparation services to aspiring college students.AGENCIES

Archaeologists at Pompeii use AI to reveal face of one of the victims

ROME: Archaeologists at the ancient Roman site of Pompeii have used artificial intelligence for the first time to digitally reconstruct the face of a victim of the AD 79 eruption of Mount Vesuvius that smothered the city, offering a new way to understand one of history's most famous natural disasters.

The digital portrait represents an older man who was among two victims discovered as they attempted to flee the city toward the coast of what is now Italy during the volcanic eruption. Researchers believe the man died earlier in the disaster, during a heavy fall of volcanic debris.

Researchers believe the man died earlier in the disaster, during a heavy fall of volcanic debris

The reconstruction was developed by the Pompeii Archaeological Park in collaboration with the University of Padua and is based on archaeological survey data from excavations near the Porta Stabia necropolis, just outside the walls of the ancient city.

Pompeii, a UNESCO World Heritage site near Naples, was buried under ash and pumice when Mount Vesuvius erupted nearly 2,000 years ago, preserving the city and thousands of its inhabitants in remarkable detail. Archaeologists found the victim holding a terracotta mortar, which they interpret as an improvised attempt to shield his head from falling lapilli, the small volcanic stones rained down during the eruption.

Ancient accounts — including those of Roman writer Pliny the Younger — describe residents using objects to protect themselves as ash and debris blanketed the city. AGENCIES

Daughter of ex-Uzbek prez goes on trial in Switzerland

GENEVA: The daughter of a former president of Uzbekistan went on trial in absentia Monday in Switzerland in connection with alleged bribery and money laundering involving assets worth hundreds of millions of dollars. Gulnara Karimova, the daughter of former President Islam Karimov, is behind bars in Uzbekistan as the trial opens in a Swiss federal criminal court in the southern city of Bellinzona. It's set to run through May 22.

Swiss prosecutors say Karimova developed and ran a crime ring known as "The Office" that involved several dozen people and multiple companies. She is accused of depositing hundreds of millions of dollars' worth of funds "of criminal origin" in Switzerland and abroad, and arranging for safe deposit boxes for the deposit of cash, jewellery and other valuables of criminal origin, prosecutors said. AGENCIES

PM Carney announces creation of Canadian sovereign wealth fund

TORONTO: Prime Minister Mark Carney announced Monday the Canadian government is developing a government-owned investment fund.

Carney said the fund will invest in major Canadian industrial projects in areas such as energy, infrastructure, mining, agriculture and technology. It will begin at 25 billion Canadian dollars (\$18 billion).

The prime minister said the federal government will put up funds alongside private investors.

The money will help fund major projects Carney's government is focused on building as Canada seeks diversify away from the United States.

US President Donald Trump has been threatening Canada's economy and sovereignty with tariffs, most offensively by claiming Canada could be "the 51st state".

“THE PM SAID THE FEDERAL GOVT WILL PUT UP FUNDS ALONGSIDE PRIVATE INVESTORS”

Carney is former two-time central banker in England and Canada as well as chair of the board of directors for Bloomberg.

"We take a lesson other jurisdictions that had the foresight many decades ago to start sovereign wealth funds," Carney said, "In some cases they began with a domestic focus then outgrew the scale of the domestic focus."

Sovereign wealth funds invest in assets, such as stocks, bonds and real estate. They are typically funded by a country's budgetary surpluses, which Canada currently does not have. AGENCIES

UK's PM faces vote on possible inquiry over Mandelson

LONDON: British Prime Minister Keir Starmer faces a serious moment of leadership peril after MPs were granted a vote in the House of Commons on Monday over whether he must face a parliamentary ethics inquiry into his conduct. Starmer has been struggling to move on from the controversy surrounding his appointment of disgraced Lord Peter Mandelson to the post of US ambassador, despite known links to convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.



British Prime Minister Keir Starmer

Now, MPs are expected to vote on Tuesday if the Privileges Committee should open an investigation into whether he misled Parliament when he claimed that "full due process" was followed in vetting the peer for the post last year.

"In this case, having taken advice, I have decided to allow the House to come to a view on whether the Committee of Privileges should look at the matter," Commons Speaker Lindsay Hoyle told members of Parliament.

This followed mounting pressure from the Opposition Conservative Party for such an investigation into Starmer's conduct. Tory leader Kemi Badenoch claimed the "facts are overwhelming" as she accused the UK PM of misleading the Commons "repeatedly" over the process that was followed ahead of Mandelson's US deployment. However, 10

Downing Street retaliated to condemn the "political stunt" by the Opposition just days before local elections are scheduled across the country on May 7.

"The government is engaging with the two parliamentary processes that are already running on Peter Mandelson's appointment with full transparency," a spokesperson said.

"This is a desperate political stunt by the Conservative Party the week before the May elections because they have no answers on the cost of living or the NHS. Their claims have no substance," the spokesperson said. As the Labour government holds a majority in the House of Commons, a large number of Starmer's own MPs would have to either vote in favour of an inquiry or abstain for the Opposition motion to proceed. The way they vote

will also indicate the scale of division within the governing party and appetite for a change of leadership.

The UK Parliament's Privileges Committee has the authority to investigate breaches of the ministerial code. AGENCIES

M.P. POWER GENERATING COMPANY LIMITED
Office of the Addl. C.E. (P&W), Shree Singaji Thermal Power Project
Dongalia Distt. Khandwa (M.P.), E-mail ID : sepnw.sstpp@gmail.com
No. 515-1700/SSTPP/MPPGCL/P&W/693
Date 27.04.2026

Tender Particulars/Tender Number	Estimated Cost (Rs.) (including GST)	Tender Cost & EMD in Rs.	Last Date and Time for Closing of Online Submission
Complete overhauling of Electrical wire rope Hoist along with supply of spares for Electrical wire rope Hoist installed at coal mill area at 2X600 MW, Stage-I, SSTPP, MPPGCL, Dongalia. (T-2026-MPPGC-487295_1)	Rs. 1,49,09,064/- (including G.S.T.)	5000/- & 2,00,000/-	21.05.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs
Annual Overhauling of L&T make ESP of Unit#3, 2X660 MW, SSTPP, MPPGCL, Dongalia. (T-2026-MPPGC-502458_1)	Rs. 74,39,000/- (including G.S.T.)	2000 & 1,48,800/-	15.05.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs

For extension & other details, the bidders are requested to please visit e-portal of GoMP at www.mptenders.gov.in

M.P. Madhyam/125498/2026

SAVE ELECTRICITY SE (P&W)

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD(R&B) DIVISION VIJAYPUR
ABBREVIATED NOTICE INVITING TENDER
e-NIT No. 05 of 2026-27 Dated.25-04-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir e-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works.

Sr. No	Name of Work	Estimated cost of Work (In Lacs)	Cost of Tender Doc. (in Rs.)	Earnest Money (In Rs.)	Time allowed for completion	Class of Contractor
1	Const. of road from Kat-walta Mandal to Degree College Purnandal via Teli Mohalla.	93.00	1500	2% of Adv. Cost	06 Months	"A"

Position of AAA :- **Accorded**
Position of T.S :- **Sanctioned**
Project Authority :- **Under UT Capex Road Sector New Works 2025-26.**

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	25-04-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 25-04-2026 to 09-05-2026
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	27-04-2026 at 1400 Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Vijaypur
4	Bid submission Start Date	25-04-2026 at 1800 Hrs
5	Bid Submission End Date	09-05-2026 upto 1700 Hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	11-05-2026 on or after 1400 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Vijaypur
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

The tender is available at website <http://jktenders.gov.in> all other terms & conditions can be seen on the above website

No. PWD/V/681-87
Dt. 25-04-2026
DIP No:DIP/J-1186/26

Sd/- Executive Engineer
PWD (R&B) Division,
Vijaypur

Branch Office : ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Manpreet Singh/ Paramjeet Kaur/ LBDEL00006213811/ H-2/ 83, F/F & S/F, Vikas Puri, Tilak Nagar, West Delhi- 110018	Property Bearing No.25 Block H-3, Upper Ground Floor, Without Roof/ Terrace Rights, Vikas Puri, New Delhi- 110018 (Along With 1/4th Undivided Sharecar Parking At Stilt Area And 1/4th Undivided Proportionate Rights of The Said Land Thereto)	02-04-2026 Rs. 19,93,901/-	27-01-2026
2.	Mohd Sagir Ahmed/ Hasrat Ahmed/ LBDEL00005497823/ H-441 Top Floor, Jaitpur Extension, Part-2, Badarpur, Delhi- 110044	Commercial Unit Bearing No. Asf 137, 2nd Floor, Gaur World Smart Street, Built On Plot No C 01A, Sector-16B, Greater Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh- 201307	02-04-2026 Rs. 18,80,489.85/-	04-01-2026
3.	Manoj Kumar/ Varsha/ LBNOD0000227948/ Plot No C63, 2nd Floor, JJ Colony, Shakurpur New, Delhi- 110034	Flat No. E-1703, 17th Floor, Block-E, "Gayatri" Awar, Situated At Gh-11, Sector-01, Noida Extension, Greater Noida West Uttar Pradesh- 201307	02-04-2026 Rs. 20,91,640/-	03-02-2026
4.	Vardan Infratech Private Limited/ Shivalik Arora/ Rajeev Arora/ LBGUR00004898939/ LBGUR00004931147/ C 107 Shivalik New Delhi, Delhi- 110017	Property No. 83,1st Floor, Rear Portion of 2nd Floor & Entire Terrace/ Roof Over And Above The 2nd Floor, In Block- D, Malviya Nagar, New Delhi- 110017	04-04-2026/ Rs. 35,82,600.57/- /Rs. 8,73,203.48/-	06-01-2026

These steps are taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower/s and/or guarantor/s (as applicable) (s) are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: April 28, 2026
Place: Delhi Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

Save Financial Services Pvt Ltd
Corporate and Registered Office :- Unit No. 782, 7th Floor, Vegas Mall, Plot No. 6, Sector 14, Dwarka, New Delhi 110075

POSSESSION NOTICE (APPENDIX IV) Under Rule 8 (1)

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Save Financial Services Pvt Ltd. (Formerly Known Karmyogee Finance India Pvt Ltd.), under Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002), and in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 13(2) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notice dated mentioned below under Section 13(2) of the said Act calling upon you being the borrowers (names and addresses mentioned below) to repay the amount mentioned in the said notice and interest thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers mentioned herein below having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers mentioned herein below and to the public in general that the undersigned has taken **Symbolic possession** of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of the Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. The borrowers mentioned here in above in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with said property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of Save Financial Services Pvt Ltd. (Formerly Known Karmyogee Finance India Pvt Ltd.) for an amount as mentioned herein under and interest thereon. The Borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets

Name of Borrower / Guarantor	Date of demand notice	Date of Symbolic Possession	Amount o/s as on date of demand notice
BTANDIR0010199, 1. Sh. Mohit S/O Jaypal Singh, 2. Sh. Mithlesh Dev W/O Jaypal Singh, Both At - Gat No. 1915 Pargana Va Tehsil Shikohabad Mauja Dakhinaa Dist Firozabad Uttar Pradesh-205135, Also At: Plot Area 1268.75 Sq Rs As 117.91 Sq Mts Gata/Khasra No. 1915 Mauza Dakhinaa Pargana/Tehsil Shikohabad Dist Firozabad, Uttar Pradesh-205135, Also At: 0 Mauja/Dakhinaa Ke Pass, Puratan School, Shikohabad, Firozabad, Near By Cold Store Ke Pass, Shikohabad Uttar Pradesh- 205135	16-Jan-2026	23-Apr-2026	Rs. 20,12,964.09/- as on 20-Jan-2026

Description Of The Immovable Property - All That Part And Piece Of The Property Bearing Plot Area 1268.75 Sq Rs As 117.91 Sq Mts Gata/Khasra No. 1915 Mauza Dakhinaa Pargana/Tehsil Shikohabad Dist Firozabad. Boundaries: North: Plot Of Land Seller, South: House Part Of Land Seller, East: 20 Wide Rasta, West: Land, Part Of Land Seller

Date - 23.04.2026, Place - Firozabad

AUTHORISED OFFICER, Save Financial Services Pvt Ltd

Bandhan Bank
Regional Office: Netaji Marg, Nr. Mithakhali Six Roads, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-6, Phone : + 91-79-26421671-75

Demand Notice to Borrowers

The under mentioned account turned into N.P.A and demand notice is issued by Bandhan Bank Ltd. to the following borrower(s), under sec.13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act (The Act), 2002 which was returned unserved. Hence, this notice is issued to you all and public at large through publication.

Name of borrower(s), and Loan Account No.	Description of mortgaged property (Secured Asset)	Date of Demand Notice/Date of NPA	O/S Amount as on Date of Demand Notice	Date of Posting of Notice
Mr. Dinesh Chand Rathour 7119000007328	All The Piece And Parcel Of Residential Plot No-92-B, Area 60 Sq Yards IE 50.1666 Sq Mtr, Khasra No-247 NM Situated At Garden Enclave Hadbast, Village mahiuddinpur, Mainpur, Pargana-Jalalabad, The & Distt-Ghaziabad-201206. Owned By Dinesh Chand Rathour And Same Bounded As Under: North : Plot No 26, East : Road 22 Feet Wide, West : Plot No 73, South : Plot No 92 A	January 15, 2026/ March 31, 2025	Rs. 77,118.57	April 15, 2026

Demand made against you through this notice to repay to the Bank dues mentioned against your name with interest, costs and charges within 60 days from the date hereof, failing which the Bank will further proceed to take steps u/s.13(4) of the SARFAESI Act. The borrowers/ mortgagors' attention is invited to the provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Place: Ghaziabad
Date: April 28, 2026

Authorised Officer
Bandhan Bank Limited

NORTHERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. DEE-TRS-GZB acting for and on behalf of President of India invites E-Tender against Tender No. **230-TRS-GZB-2025-26-32**. The details are as under:

1. Name of the work	'Attending and Filling up of dry, screened, clean sand in sandbox after draining out of moist or wet sand if any inside the sandbox along with its disposal at provided place and ensuring free flow of sand in AC Electric Locomotives with supply of sand conforming to RDSO specification No. AARM-916-51 and packed in 10 kg water proof bags for use in Electric Locomotives sanding equipment round the clock' at Electric Loco Shed, Ghaziabad.
2. Approx. cost of work	₹ 43,31,858.40
3. Earnest Money to be deposited	₹ 86,600.00
4. Last Date & Time of Submission of tender bid of tender	22.05.2026 (15:00 Hrs.)
5. Date & Time of opening of tender document	22.05.2026 (After 15:00 Hrs.)
6. Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in

Note : (i) The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement System (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for participating in e-tender system. (ii) For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. (iii) No manual offers are acceptable. (iv) Cost of Tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only. No. 230-TRS-GZB-2025-26-32 Dated: 25.04.2026 1391/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

GOVERNMENT OF PUNJAB
PATIALA URBAN PLANNING & DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
PUDA Complex, Urban Estate Phase-II, Patiala

PUBLIC NOTICE

CANCELLATION OF TENDER OF EMPANELLED INDEPENDENT VALUERS FOR DETERMINATION OF RESERVE PRICE OF UNSOLD SITES

Patiala Urban Planning and Development Authority (PDA) invited sealed bids from independent valuers empaneled with Nationalized Banks/Income Tax Department in the double envelope system for the valuation of reserve prices of various sites (residential/commercial plots, institutional/industrial sites, etc.) as per the notification issued by the Government of Punjab bearing No. H-U-11020/1/2025-SH1/1/1224389/1 dated 16.10.2025, tenders/documents were invited though Newspaper from 20.12.2025 to 02.01.2026. In this regard, a total of 07 firms submitted their tenders/documents

After examining the documents received from various valuers/firms, it has been observed that out of these 07 valuers/firms, 05 firms did not submit complete documents. Therefore, as per the policy, it is not possible to allocate the work to 03 of these firms/valuers. Accordingly, this office has decided to cancel the tender issued on 02.01.2026.

A fresh invitation for the tender will be issued soon through a public notice.

Estate Officer
PDA, Patiala

PR-Advt. No : 1319/12/2026-27/10906

KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS!

IMPORTANT INFORMATION

SUMMER SPECIAL TRAINS

In order to clear extra rush of passengers during the upcoming Summer Season, Railways have decided to run the following Summer Special Trains as per details given below:

05579/05580 Purnia Court-Anand Vihar (T)-Purnia Court Special (Bi-Weekly)				44 Trips	
Train No. 05579	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	ARR.	DEP.
---	---	16:30	Purnia Court	13:45	---
01:05	---	---	Anand Vihar (T)	---	05:15

Days of run : 05579 Ex. Purnia Court from 26.04.2026 to 12.07.2026 (Except 22.05.2025) (Friday, Sunday) 05580 Ex. Anand Vihar(T) from 28.04.2026 to 14.07.2026 (Except 24.05.2026) (Sunday, Tuesday).

Composition: 3 Tier AC Economy, Sleeper & General

Stoppages: Banmankhi Jn., Murliganj, Dauram Madhepura, Saharsa Jn., Garh Baruari, Supaul, New Jhajha Jn. (instead of Saraygarh), Nirmali, Ghoghardiha, Jhanjharpur Jn., Sakri Jn., Shisho, Janakpur Road, Sitamarhi Jn., Baigania, Raxaul Jn., Narkatiaganj Jn., Bagaha, Kaptanganj Jn., Gorakhpur Jn., Basti, Gonda Jn., Sitapur Jn., Shahjahanpur Jn., Bareilly Jn., Moradabad, Hapur & Ghaziabad Stations.

05575/05576 Saharsa Jn-Anand Vihar (T)-Saharsa Jn. Special (Weekly)				24 Trips	
Train No. 05575	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	ARR.	DEP.
---	---	20:00	Saharsa Jn.	10:30	---
01:05	---	---	Anand Vihar (T)	---	05:15

Days of run : 05575 Ex. Saharsa Jn. from 28.04.2026 to 14.07.2026 (Tuesday) 05576 Ex. Anand Vihar(T) from 30.04.2026 to 16.07.2026 (Thursday).

Composition: 3 Tier AC Economy, Sleeper & General

Stoppages: Garh Baruari, Supaul, New Jhajha Jn., Nirmali, Ghoghardiha, Jhanjharpur Jn., Sakri Jn., Shisho, Janakpur Road, Sitamarhi Jn., Baigania, Raxaul Jn., Narkatiaganj Jn., Bagaha, Kaptanganj Jn., Gorakhpur Jn., Basti, Gonda Jn., Sitapur Jn., Shahjahanpur Jn., Bareilly Jn., Moradabad, Hapur & Ghaziabad Stations.

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For any kind of information and detailed time-table etc., passengers are requested to contact RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or may visit Indian Railways website <https://enquiry.indianrail.gov.in> or NTES App.

1412/2026

India and New Zealand free trade agreement: An explainer

FTA will come into force on actually decided date agreed by both sides

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and New Zealand on Monday signed a free trade agreement (FTA) to boost two-way commerce in goods and services and promote investments. The pact will come into force on actually decided date agreed by both sides.

Here are a few questions and answers to understand the main strategic gain of this deal:

BENEFITS FOR INDIA:

The FTA provides duty-free access for 100 per cent of India's exports to New Zealand. Earlier, New Zealand maintained peak tariffs of up to 10 per cent on key Indian exports, including ceramics, carpets, automobiles, and auto components.

New Zealand has committed to invest (FDI) \$20 billion over 15 years.

India has secured commitments across a wide range of high-value services sectors, including IT and IT-enabled services, professional services, education, financial services, tourism, construction and other business services.

The FTA Opens Skilled Employment Pathways through a new Temporary Employment Entry Visa pathway for Indian professionals in skilled occupations, with a quota of 5,000



The FTA provides duty-free access for 100 per cent of India's exports to New Zealand

visas at any given time and a stay of up to three years.

Duty-free wine and spirits exports from India, while wines from the Oceania country will enter the domestic market at a concessional duty, which will be reduced over a period of 10 years.

BENEFITS FOR NEW ZEALAND:

India, following the template used in its trade agreement with Australia, has offered market access on 70 per cent of tariff lines (or product categories). The country will give duty-free access to 54.11 per cent of New Zealand exports from day one of the implemen-

Highlights

- » New Zealand has committed to facilitating \$20 billion in FDI into India over 15 years
- » India has offered market access on 70% of tariff lines (or product categories)
- » India has not given any concessions to New Zealand on sensitive sectors, including dairy, animal products, vegetables, sugar, etc

tation of the free trade agreement, and these goods include sheep meat, wool, coal and several forestry and wood products, a move which is expected to make these items cheaper for Indian consumers.

Duty concessions on agricultural goods like apples, kiwifruit, manuka honey, and albumins (including milk albumin), but with quotas and minimum import prices (MIP).

Duties on several seafood items, such as mussels and salmon, will be eliminated over a period of seven years.

The levy will be removed on a number of iron, steel and scrap aluminium items over a

period of 10 years or less.

Sensitive farm products, including apples, kiwifruit, manuka honey, and albumins (including milk albumin), are managed through tariff-rate quotas (TRQs), supported by minimum import prices (MIPs) and safeguard measures.

Further, the import duty on avocados and persimmons by India will be eliminated in 10 years.

SENSITIVE GOODS:

To protect the interests of farmers and MSMEs, India has not extended any import duty concessions to New Zealand on several sensitive sectors, including dairy, animal products, vegetables, sugar, copper, and aluminium.

Products that are kept in the exclusion list are: Dairy (milk, cream, whey, yoghurt, cheese, etc), animal products (other than sheep meat), vegetable products (onions, chana, peas, corn, almonds, etc), sugar, artificial honey, animal, vegetable or microbial fats and oils.

The list also includes arms and ammunition, gems and jewellery, copper and articles (cathodes, cartridges, rods, bars, coils), aluminium and articles thereof (ingots, billets, wire bars).

INVESTMENTS:

New Zealand has committed to facilitating \$20 billion in foreign direct investment into India over 15 years. At present, India has received just about \$89 million FDI during April 2000 and December 2025.

IMPORTANCE FOR INDIA:

For India, the agreement strengthens access to a high-income, rules-based Pacific market and supports its broader Indo-Pacific economic strategy.

For New Zealand, it offers more secure entry into one of the world's fastest-growing large economies at a time of rising global trade uncertainty.

New Zealand's Indian diaspora of over 300,000 people — about 5 per cent of its population — provides a strong bridge for trade and investment. Easier visas, faster student pathways and lower education costs could further boost services trade.

BILATERAL TRADE:

Bilateral merchandise trade stood at \$1.3 billion (\$711.1 million in exports and \$587.1 million in imports) in 2024-25, while total trade in goods and services reached about \$2.4 billion in 2024, with services trade alone reaching \$1.24 billion, led by travel, IT, and business services.

Markets rebound after three-day decline, Sensex jumps 639 points

Rupee appreciates just one paisa to 94.15 against dollar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty rebounded nearly 1 per cent on Monday, snapping the three-day falling streak following a rally in Reliance Industries and Sun Pharma and positive global trends.

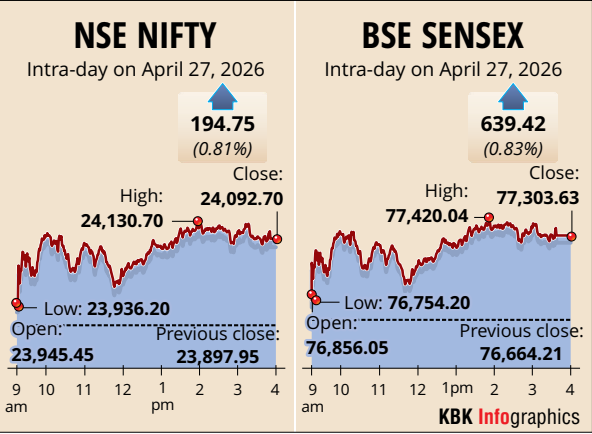
The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 639.42 points or 0.83 per cent to settle at 77,303.63. During the day, it surged 755.83 points or 0.98 per cent to 77,420.04.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 194.75 points or 0.81 per cent to close at 24,092.70.

Among the 30-Sensex firms, Sun Pharma jumped 7 per cent after it announced the acquisition of US-based Organon & Co in an all-cash deal at an enterprise valuation of \$11.75 billion, one of the largest overseas buyouts by Indian firms. Reliance Industries jumped 2.88 per cent. Adani Ports, Tech Mahindra, Mahindra & Mahindra, NTPC, HCL Tech and TCS were also among the major gainers.

Axis Bank, Bharat Electronics, Trent and ICICI Bank were among the laggards from the blue-chip pack.

"The upmove was primarily driven by a rebound in beaten-down heavyweights across sectors, particularly Reliance, along with positive developments such as a sharp rally in pharma majors following global acquisition news. Additionally, optimism around potential progress in US-Iran negotiations supported global sentiment, even as crude oil prices remained elevated," Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.



A total of 3,075 stocks advanced, 1,288 declined and 193 remained unchanged on the BSE

nationally, optimism around potential progress in US-Iran negotiations supported global sentiment, even as crude oil prices remained elevated," Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

The BSE SmallCap Select index jumped 2 per cent and MidCap Select index climbed 1.35 per cent.

All sectoral indices ended higher. Utilities surged the most by 2.50 per cent, followed by Healthcare (2.43 per cent), Focused IT (2.41 per cent), Realty (2.35 per cent), IT (2.20

per cent), Power (2.05 per cent) and Services (1.92 per cent).

A total of 3,075 stocks advanced, while 1,288 declined and 193 remained unchanged on the BSE.

The rupee settled on a flat note, registering gains of just one paisa to close at 94.15 against the US dollar on Monday, as rising global uncertainty, escalating tensions in West Asia and soaring crude oil prices weighed on investor sentiments.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded 2.53 per cent higher at \$107.9 per barrel.

FII's offloaded equities worth Rs 8,827.87 crore on Friday, according to exchange data. On Friday, the Sensex dropped 999.79 points or 1.29 per cent to settle at 76,664.21. The Nifty slumped 275.10 points or 1.14 per cent to end at 23,897.95.

NSE sells 1% stake in IGX to comply with regulatory requirements

NEW DELHI: The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has offloaded around 1 per cent stake in Indian Gas Exchange (IGX) to comply with regulatory requirements, sources said on Monday.

The stake sale is part of NSE's effort to align with Petroleum & Natural Gas Regulatory Board norms, which mandate that no single entity holds more than 25 per cent in the exchange.

Following the latest dilution, NSE's shareholding in IGX has come down to 25 per cent. Notably, the exchange had acquired a 26 per cent stake in IGX for over Rs 19 crore in March 2021 to become a co-promoter, after securing approvals from PNGRB.

Earlier this month, NSE partnered with IGX to introduce exchange-traded derivatives based on domestic natural gas prices. As part of the collaboration, NSE will launch natural gas futures contracts linked to IGX's benchmark price index -- Gas Indx of India (GIXI), reflecting pricing based on actual trades on the IGX platform.

Moreover, IGX in January announced plans to launch an IPO by December this year. The draft papers are expected to be filed with the Sebi in the second quarter of calendar year 2026, Managing Director and CEO Rajesh Kumar Mediratta had said.

Trade agreement with EU & US in next few months: Piyush Goyal

NEW DELHI: Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Monday said the free trade agreement with New Zealand is the seventh such pact signed under his tenure in the past three-and-a-half years and two more agreements with the European Union and the US are expected in the coming months.

Goyal and visiting New Zealand's Trade and Investment Minister Todd McClay here inked a free trade agreement, which is expected to come into force by the end of this year.

"With this (India-New Zealand) FTA, it is the seventh free trade agreement that I am signing in the last three and a half years. Two more to go very soon in the next few months with the European Union (EU) and the United States of America (USA)," he told reporters here.



India and the 27-nation bloc EU in January announced the closure of negotiations for a trade pact. It has not been signed yet.

The NDA government has so far finalised FTAs with the UAE (implemented in May 2022), Australia (implemented in December 2022), the UK (signed in July 2025), EFTA bloc (implemented in October 2025), Oman (signed in December 2025), European Union (announced closure of negotiations in January 2026),

and Mauritius (came into force from April 2021).

The remarks are important as an Indian official team returned from Washington last week after holding three-day talks with US authorities on finalising the first phase of the bilateral trade agreement.

Both sides discussed several areas, such as market access, non-tariff measures, technical barriers to trade, customs and trade facilitation, investment promotion, economic security alignment and digital trade.

India and the US issued a joint statement on February 7 finalising a framework for an interim trade agreement regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade. The framework requires recalibration in view of changes in the US tariff landscape.

Bharat ki Soch: Experts deliberate on integrating indigenous healing into mainstream healthcare

NEW DELHI: A two-day national conference on "Local Health Traditions in India: Recognition, Legitimate Space and Policy Pathways," organised by Bharat Ki Soch, brought together scholars, practitioners and policymakers to deliberate on preserving, validating and integrating indigenous healing systems into mainstream healthcare.

Advisor Raghvendra Singh delivered the welcome address, followed by opening remarks from Chairman Anil Rajput. "At Bharat Ki Soch, we believe that India's healthcare system can be strengthened by meaningfully drawing upon the wisdom of its civilizational heritage by documenting,



standardizing and applying it to contemporary challenges," said Rajput, stressing the need to restore the rightful place of local health traditions.

Delivering the keynote, Prof. Amitabh Pande, Director, Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Manav Sangrahalaya, Bhopal, highlighted the role of com-

munity-based, cost-effective traditional systems, especially in rural and tribal areas, and called for a health-pluralist policy framework.

The inaugural session concluded with remarks by R K Pachnanda, who said, "In the 21st century, marked by lifestyle illnesses and stress,

local healers provide accessible and culturally relevant care, particularly in places where allopathic clinics have no reach."

The conference featured speakers including Prof. Sunita Reddy, Prof. G. Harirama-murthi, Prof. Nemthianngai Guite, Anil Jauhri, Dr. Imlikumba, Manjeet Singh Saluja, Prof. V. Sujatha, Prof. P. Unnikrishnan, Ankita Toppo, Ruth Kerketta, Prof. Ritu Priya and Dr. J. R. Bhatt.

Discussions underscored the need for policy recognition, documentation, capacity building, and institutional support to integrate local health traditions into India's healthcare system.



of the OTC foreign exchange derivative contracts involving INR undertaken by its offshore related parties to the Trade Repository (TR) of Clearing Corporation of India Ltd (CCIL), RBI said in a circular.

"All OTC deliverable and non-deliverable foreign exchange derivative contracts involving INR, undertaken globally by the related parties of the AD Cat-I bank in India

RBI said banks will have the option of not reporting transactions where the notional of the contract does not exceed \$1 million

shall be reported," it said. Providing operational flexibility to the banks, RBI said they will have the option of not reporting transactions where the notional of the contract does not exceed \$1 million or equivalent.

They will also not be required to report transactions undertaken in terms of the back-to-back arrangement and transactions undertaken by

the related parties with other AD Cat-I banks in India.

As part of the flexibility, the central bank has also laid down a phased roadmap for the reporting.

The circular said that from July 1, 2027, banks will have to report all foreign exchange derivative contracts involving INR undertaken by their parent, including the branches of the parent.

Reporting coverage for other related parties should reach at least 70 per cent of the notional value by July 2027, 80 per cent by January 2028, and 100 per cent by July 2028.

According to the circular, transaction will have to be reported preferably on the date of transaction, but in any case, within two working days from the date of transaction.

India-New Zealand Business Meet: Agra to become global 'Shoe Capital'

NEW DELHI: Agra is set to position itself as the "Shoe Capital of the World," with the initiative launched at the India-New Zealand Business Meet held at Hotel Amar Vilas on Sunday.

The event, attended by Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and New Zealand's Minister for Trade and Investment Todd McClay, underscored the potential of Agra's footwear sector to drive Uttar Pradesh's economy.

Agra already accounts for over 75 per cent of India's leather footwear exports. Officials projected that exports from the state could rise 3-5 times through free trade agreements and bilateral partner-

The city's footwear cluster includes over 5,000 MSMEs, employing 4-5 lakh people

ships. Collaboration with New Zealand in raw materials and design innovation is expected to expand access to markets such as Europe, the United States and the Middle East.

The city's footwear cluster includes over 5,000 MSMEs, employing 4-5 lakh people. The initiative is expected to expand these units, create jobs, and reduce migration. Infrastructure upgrades, including the

upcoming Noida International Airport and a proposed footwear park under YEIDA, will improve logistics and attract global buyers.

The plan also focuses on global branding, GI tagging, and joint manufacturing with international partners, boosting foreign investment and technology adoption. Goyal said the government will support the sector through policy measures such as zero duty on components and interest subsidies until 2030.

Industry leaders, including Ramesh Kumar Juneja and Puran Dawar, termed the initiative transformative for Uttar Pradesh's \$1 trillion economy goal.

NSE registered investor base crosses 13 crore

Demographically, the median investor age has declined to 33 years

MUMBAI: The National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) has crossed 13 crore unique registered investors as of April 27, 2026, adding one crore investors in about seven months since September 2025. Total client codes reached 25.7 crore as of April 25, having crossed 25 crore in February.

Investor expansion has accelerated sharply over time. After taking 14 years to reach the first crore and 11 more years to add three crore, NSE has been adding roughly one crore investors every 6-8 months.

The investor base grew at a CAGR of 26.4 per cent between

CLOSER LOOK

- » After taking 14 years to reach first crore, NSE has been adding roughly one crore investors every 6-8 months
- » Investor base grew at a CAGR of 26.4% between FY21 & FY26, compared with 15.2% in previous five years
- » Market capitalisation of NSE-listed companies rose at an 18 per cent CAGR to Rs 460.6 lakh crore

FY21 and FY26, compared with 15.2 per cent in the previous five years, reflecting rising retail participation aided by digital access and policy support.

Market performance has supported this trend, with the Nifty 50 and Nifty 500 deliver-

ing annualised returns of 10.8 per cent and 13.3 per cent, respectively, over five years.

NSE-listed firms' market capitalisation rose at an 18 per cent CAGR to Rs 460.6 lakh crore, with individual investors holding 18.6 per cent as of

December 2025. Demographically, the median investor age has declined to 33 years, with nearly 40 per cent under 30, and women now accounting for about one-fourth of investors.

The investor base spans 99.85 per cent of India's pin codes, led by Maharashtra (2 crore), Uttar Pradesh (1.5 crore) and Gujarat (1.1 crore). Smaller states and cities have seen strong growth, while mutual fund participation remains robust, with 7.2 crore new SIP accounts added in FY26 and average monthly inflows rising to Rs 29,132 crore.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE

Dr. Abhilash Likhri, Secretary, Department of Fisheries, GoI leads a high-level delegation, participating in the 5th World Small-Scale Fisheries Congress, Hua Hin, Thailand from April 27 – 30, 2026 being organised by FAO and TBTI Global. The event is centred around the theme 'Small-scale fisheries for advancing just harmony, young futures, and regenerative wisdom' focusing on promoting justice and conflict resolution in coastal and ocean region, empowering youth in fisheries and ocean stewardship, and promoting regenerative, climate friendly practices rooted in traditional knowledge.

PNB Chandigarh Circle organised an MSME outreach program at CII, Sector 31, Chandigarh. The program was chaired by Sanjeev Kumar Dhupar, Chief General Manager from the Head Office. The chief guest was Diprava Lakra, Finance Secretary, Chandigarh. Also present on the occasion were Ashish Chaturvedi, Chandigarh Zonal Manager, Sanjeev Kumar Jha, Chandigarh Circle Head, and Siddharth Mittal, MCC Head. Over 100 customers attended the event. In the MSME outreach programme, 119 leads worth Rs 187 crore were generated by Chandigarh Division and 589 leads worth Rs 1270 crore were generated by the entire Chandigarh Zone.

India plans to import 64 LT urea for this kharif season

India will also import 19 LT of other fertilisers including 12 LT of DAP, 4 LT of TSP & 3 LT of Ammonium Sulphate

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India plans to import 64 lakh tonnes of urea and 19 lakh tonnes of other fertilisers this kharif season as the West Asia crisis has driven up global prices by nearly double, raising import bill, the government said on Monday.

Addressing an inter-ministerial briefing on the impact of recent developments in West Asia, Aparna S Sharma, Additional Secretary in the Department of Fertilisers, said retail prices of urea and Di Ammonium Phosphate (DAP) would remain unchanged, and there is adequate supply for the kharif season.

“MRP of fertilisers like urea and DAP remain the same. There has been no change,” she said.

Urea continues to be sold at Rs 266.50 per 45 kg bag and DAP at Rs 1,350 per 50 kg bag. Of the planned imports, 9.4 lakh tonne of urea has already been received since the crisis began. Another 13.07 lakh tonnes were secured through a global tender in February, while 25 lakh tonnes more have been tendered and are expected to arrive in May.

“Most of the imports are out of the Strait of Hormuz. We are



very much sure that we will be getting the supplies on time,” the official said.

On domestic production, Sharma said output had taken a hit in March due to force majeure on gas deliveries, bringing plant utilisation down to 60-65 per cent.

“Now we have taken measures to import gas even at a higher cost. Availability of gas for urea units, which earlier was 60-65 per cent, is now 97 per cent. So our urea production has been very good after that,” she said.

Post-crisis domestic urea production has reached 35.4 lakh tonne. The government has also floated a global tender

for the import of 19 lakh tonnes of non-urea fertilisers, comprising 12 lakh tonnes of DAP, 4 lakh tonnes of Triple Superphosphate (TSP), and 3 lakh tonnes of Ammonium Sulphate, to ensure adequate supplies during the peak kharif season.

A call for further import of urea and non-urea fertilisers will be made after assessing domestic production and demand.

For the period April 1 to April 26, urea availability stood at 71.58 lakh tonne against a requirement of 18.17 lakh tonne. DAP availability was 22.35 lakh tonne as against a requirement of 5.90 lakh tonne. MoP availability stood at 12.46

Highlights

» ‘Retail prices of urea & DAP would remain unchanged & there is adequate supply for the kharif season’

» Urea continues to be sold at Rs 266.50/45 kg bag & DAP at Rs 1,350/50 kg bag

» Of the planned imports, 9.4 LT of urea has already been received

lakh tonne and SSP at 26.26 lakh tonne.

For the 2026 kharif season, the total fertiliser requirement has been assessed at 390.54 lakh tonnes, against which an opening stock of 190.21 lakh tonnes — nearly 49 per cent of the seasonal requirement — is already in place.

“There is a strong supply situation for the kharif season. No shortages have been reported so far,” Sharma said.

The Department of Fertilisers reaffirmed that fertiliser security remains “strong, stable and well managed” with availability consistently exceeding requirements across all major fertilisers.

Sun Pharma to acquire US-based Organon & Co for \$11.75 billion enterprise valuation

Company has signed definitive pact under which Sun Pharma will acquire all outstanding shares of Organon for \$14/share in an all-cash transaction

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Sun Pharmaceutical Industries Ltd will acquire US-based Organon & Co in an all-cash deal at an enterprise valuation of \$11.75 billion in one of the largest acquisitions by Indian firms overseas.

The company has signed a definitive agreement under which Sun Pharma will acquire all outstanding shares of Organon for \$14 per share in an all-cash transaction with an enterprise valuation of \$11.75 billion, Sun Pharmaceutical Industries said in a statement on Monday.

Organon is a global healthcare company formed through a spinoff from Merck, known as MSD outside of the US and Canada, in 2021. It has six manufacturing facilities across the European Union and emerging markets.

Upon successful consummation of the transaction, Sun Pharma is poised to be among the top 25 global pharmaceutical companies with a combined revenue of \$12.4 billion, a leading player in established brands and branded generics, the company said.

Sun Pharma’s acquisition of Organon will be among the top overseas acquisitions by Indian firms, which include Tata Steel’s \$12 billion takeover of Corus for \$12 billion in 2007 and Bharti Airtel’s \$10.7 billion deal to buy



Organon is a global healthcare company formed through a spinoff from Merck, known as MSD outside of the US & Canada, in 2021

Kuwait-based Zain Telecom’s African business in 2010.

Commenting on the acquisition, Sun Pharma Executive Chairman Dilip Shanghvi said, “This transaction represents a significant opportunity for Sun Pharma to build on its vision of ‘reaching people and touching lives. Organon’s portfolio, capabilities and global reach are highly complementary to our own, and we believe that bringing the two organisations together can create a stronger and more diversified platform.”

Organon Executive Chair Carrie Cox said, “Following a comprehensive review of strategic alternatives, our Board determined that this all-cash

Key Points

» Organon has six manufacturing facilities across European Union and emerging markets

» Upon successful consummation of transaction, Sun Pharma is poised to be among top 25 global pharma cos with a combined revenue of \$12.4 billion

» Sun Pharma’s acquisition of Organon will be among the top overseas acquisitions by Indian firms

transaction offers compelling and immediate value to Organon stockholders. We believe Sun Pharma is well-positioned to support Organon’s businesses, employees and patients globally, and to further advance our commitment to delivering impactful medicines and solutions.”

Post the transaction, Sun Pharma said it will also become a top-three company in global women’s health, creating a commercial platform for future growth and the 7th largest global biosimilar player.

It will have a presence in 150 countries, with 18 large markets, each generating over \$100 million in revenues after the deal is

completed. In an investor presentation, Sun Pharma said the combined business will unlock several vectors of value creation with potential synergies of over \$350 million in 2-4 years.

The transaction has been approved by the boards of directors of both Sun Pharma and Organon and is expected to close in early 2027 subject to customary closing conditions, including receipt of required regulatory approvals and approval by Organon stockholders.

For Sun Pharma, the Organon acquisition is the latest in a series of successful acquisitions which include the \$4 billion takeover of erstwhile Ranbaxy in 2014 and the acquisition of Israel’s Taro Pharmaceutical Industries in a deal valued at \$454 million in 2007.

Organon is a global leader in women’s health. It has a portfolio comprising over 70 products across women’s health and general medicines, which includes biosimilars, commercialised across 140 countries, with the US, Europe, China, Canada, and Brazil among its largest markets, the statement by Sun Pharma said.

For the year ended December 31, 2025, Organon reported \$6.2 billion in revenue and adjusted EBITDA of \$1.9 billion. It had debt of \$8.6 billion and cash balance of \$574 million, the statement said.

SBI Card Q4 profit up 14% to ₹609 crore



NEW DELHI: SBI Card on Monday reported 14 per cent rise in profit to Rs 609 crore for the fourth quarter ended March 2026.

SBI Cards & Payment Services Ltd had earned a profit of Rs 534 crore a year ago. Total income improved to Rs 5,187 crore from Rs 4,832 crore in the year-ago period, a BSE filing by the company said.

However, interest income declined to Rs 2,382 crore in Q4 FY26 from Rs 2,415 crore in the same quarter a year ago.

During the quarter, gross NPSs moderated to 2.41 per cent of gross advances against 3.08 per cent as of March 31, 2025. Net NPAs too declined to 1.04 per cent as compared to 1.46 per cent. As a result, impairment losses and bad debts eased to Rs 1,097 crore from Rs 1,245 crore a year ago. For the full fiscal 2025-26, profit increased 13 per cent to Rs 2,167 crore from Rs 1,916 crore a year ago. Total income increased to Rs 20,708 crore from Rs 18,637 crore.

The size of the company’s balance sheet as of March 31, 2026, was Rs 66,328 crore against Rs 65,546 crore a year ago. PFI

Free service expectation posing significant barrier in public WiFi expansion, says Trai

‘Indian consumers have been conditioned by the aggressive pricing of 4G/5G mobile data to view internet connectivity as a near-zero-cost commodity’

NEW DELHI: Expectation of free WiFi service is creating a significant psychological and economic barrier in the expansion of public WiFi networks, telecom regulator Trai said in a consultation paper released on Monday.

The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai) in the consultation paper on “Proliferation of Public Wi-Fi Networks in India” said that Indian consumers have been conditioned by the aggressive pricing of 4G/5G mobile data to view internet connectivity as a near-zero-cost commodity and are reluctant to buy a voucher for a Public WiFi Hotspot even at

a nominal rate of Rs 5 or Rs 10.

“The widespread expectation of “free Wi-Fi” acts as a significant psychological and economic barrier to the expansion of Public Wi-Fi, as it directly weakens the commercial viability of hotspot providers that operate on paid or freemium business models,” Trai said.

The regulator said that competitive data tariffs, and convenience of mobile usage in India have unintentionally created a major structural challenge for the adoption and commercial sustainability of Public WiFi networks..

“From a user behaviour

standpoint, mobile data provides a seamless, always-on experience: there is no need to scan for networks, manually authenticate, purchase vouchers, or deal with login portals,” Trai said.

It said that Public Wi-Fi service, especially under decentralized models like PM-WANI, often requires several extra steps including discovering the hotspot, connecting, authenticating via an app or OTP, and purchasing a small voucher which most users perceive these steps as unnecessary hassles when their mobile data already works fast enough.

“As a result, even in areas

where Public Wi-Fi is deployed, actual usage remains low because the “switching cost” in terms of time and effort outweighs the marginal financial savings. This impacts the Public Wi-Fi provider/PDO who operate the hotspots,” Trai said.

The regulator has sought views from interested parties on the mechanism and strategy that should be adopted for proliferation of public wifi networks even if the government agrees to provide financial support for their expansion.

Trai has fixed May 25 as the last date for comments on the paper and June 8 for counter comments. PFI

Silver jumps ₹3,500, gold rises to 1.56 lakh/10 gms

NEW DELHI: Silver prices rebounded by Rs 3,500 to Rs 2.50 lakh per kg in the national capital on Monday, while gold edged higher to Rs 1.56 lakh per 10 grams amid fresh buying by jewellers and retailers. The white metal had closed at Rs 2,47,000 per kg in the previous session.

According to the All India Sarafa Association, gold of 99.9 per cent purity gained Rs 200 to Rs 1,56,100 per 10 grams.

“Gold traded steady on Monday, holding within the previous session’s range as markets navigated mixed global cues,” Saumil Gandhi,

Senior Analyst - Commodities at HDFC Securities, said.

In the international markets, both spot gold and silver traded marginally lower at \$4,704 and 75.60 per ounce, respectively. “Spot gold slipped as US-Iran talks stalled, which pushed up oil prices, stoking inflation concerns,” Praveen Singh, Head of commodities at Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

However, the metal recovered later and was trading steadily at \$4,710 per ounce amid reports that Iran has given the US a new proposal to reopen Strait of Hormuz & end the conflict, he added. PFI

‘India’s gold investment demand hits decade high in 2025, ETF inflows surpass 10-yr tally’

NEW DELHI: Gold investment demand in India climbed to nearly 40% of total consumption in calendar year 2025, the highest in recent years, driven by strong ETF inflows and global uncertainties, according to CareEdge Ratings.

ETF inflows alone added 37.5 tonnes during the year—exceeding the combined investment of the previous decade—as investors increasingly shifted away from jewellery amid record prices and geopolitical tensions. The agency expects investment demand to remain elevated at 35-40% of total consumption by FY27, supported by portfolio diversification, central bank



buying and continued macro-economic uncertainty.

Gold prices are likely to stay firm through 2026, albeit with intermittent volatility. “Geopolitical uncertainty, rising gold prices and portfolio diversification preferences will continue to drive investment demand,” said Akhil Goyal, Director at CareEdge Ratings.

The trend is reshaping India’s gold consumption

mix. Jewellery, which historically accounted for about 70% of demand, dropped below 60% in 2025. While jewellery demand rose 10% year-on-year in value terms to Rs 4.8 lakh crore, volumes fell 15% as consumers opted for lighter and lower-carat products.

Large organised jewellers are expected to post revenue growth of around 35% in FY26, aided by store expansion and market share gains from sector formalisation. Growth is likely to moderate to 20-25% in FY27. “Organised retailers will benefit from steady demand, formalisation and expansion plans,” said Raunak Modi, Assistant Director at CareEdge.

Margins are projected to improve in FY26 due to inventory gains before normalising in FY27, with EBITDA margins seen at 6.5-7%. CareEdge noted that six major listed jewellers added about 310 stores in FY26, marking the second consecutive year of 300-plus additions, though expansion is becoming more measured.

Franchise-led expansion continues to rise, accounting for 62% of stores. Meanwhile, silver is gaining traction among younger buyers but is unlikely to replace gold. India’s reliance on imports means higher value demand will continue to support import requirements despite lower volumes. AGENCIES

Coal India profit rises 11% to ₹10,839 cr in Q4

NEW DELHI: State-owned CIL on Monday reported an 11.1 per cent rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 10,839.18 crore in the March quarter, driven by higher revenue. Coal India Ltd (CIL) logged a consolidated net profit of Rs 9,751.64 crore in the year-ago period.

In a filing to the BSE, the Maharatna firm said its revenue from operations rose to Rs 46,490.03 crore from Rs 43,961.56 in the corresponding quarter of the previous fiscal year.

The consolidated expenses of the company during the fourth quarter of the previous

fiscal year rose to Rs 37,107.07 crore compared to Rs 34,999 crore in the year-ago period, CIL said in a filing to the BSE.

However, the company’s net profit for the year ended March 31, 2026 dropped to Rs 31,094.29 crore over Rs 35,505.79 crore for the year ended March 31, 2025.

The revenue for 2025-26 marginally declined to Rs 1,68,400.29 crore over Rs 1,69,177.37 crore for the year ended March 31, 2025.

The board of directors declared a final dividend of Rs 5.25 per equity share for 2025-26. PFI

UltraTech Cement posts ₹3,000 cr profit in March qtr

It had posted a net profit of Rs 2,474.79 crore in the January-March period a year ago

CLOSER LOOK

» Revenue from operations was at Rs 25,799.47 crore in Q4 FY26. It was at Rs 23,063.32 crore a year earlier

» For the entire fiscal 2025-26, UltraTech profit reported profit of Rs 8,188.35 crore

» The total consolidated income was at Rs 89,089.04 crore for the financial year ended March 31, 2026

vious corresponding period” due to the acquisition of south-based India Cements Ltd (ICL), Birla White WallCare (earlier known as Wonder WallCare) and Ras Al Khaimah, UAE-based RAKWCT.

Total expenses of UltraT-

ech were at Rs 21,894.18 crore.

During the quarter, the company achieved ‘highest ever sales volume,’ it said in an earnings statement. “Grey cement sales volumes for India reached 42.41 million tonnes in the quarter, rising 9.3 per cent

year-on-year, as capacity utilisation surged to 89 per cent, propelled by robust demand across housing, infrastructure, and commercial construction segments,” the company said.

UltraTech’s total consolidated income, which includes other income as well, was at Rs 25,887.03 crore in the March quarter.

In the entire FY26, Ultra-

Tech profit was at Rs 8,188.35 crore. The total consolidated income was at Rs 89,089.04 crore for the financial year ended March 31, 2026.

For the full year, total grey cement volumes for India were

145 million tonnes. “Against the backdrop of a challenging geopolitical environment, UltraTech delivered exceptional results across every dimension of performance -- volumes, revenues, profitability, and balance sheet strength,” the company said.

Its energy costs declined 3 per cent year-on-year, powered by a meaningfully higher green power mix — which now stands at 43 per cent of total power consumption versus 34.4 per cent in the preceding year — alongside an expanded alternative fuel and raw material (AFR) mix and improved conversion ratios. PFI

MobiKwik Group secures NBFC licence from Reserve Bank

NEW DELHI: Fintech firm One MobiKwik Systems’s application for a non-banking financial company (NBFC) licence has been approved by the RBI, the company said on Monday.

The firm said the NBFC licence will enable it to launch a new lending division — MobiKwik Financial Services Private Limited (MFSP), a wholly owned subsidiary), which will help expand its regulated lending capabilities, design credit products, and serve a broader base of consumers and merchants.

“The NBFC application approval is a pivotal step in MobiKwik Group’s evolution into a scaled financial services platform. We are especially happy that the application has been approved in under four months, which is an endorsement of the credibility of the Group, and are grateful to the RBI for repositing its faith in us,” Upasana Taku, Executive Director, Co-founder and CFO, MobiKwik, said.

The NBFC will build on the group’s inherent strengths of having over 18.6 crore customer base as well as strong tech infrastructure, risk underwriting and collection capabilities. PFI

RCB's powerplay DC-struction

Bengaluru pacers unleash powerplay carnage to flatten Capitals

BENGALURU: Royal Challengers Bengaluru rode a storm of sheer pace fury to annihilate Delhi Capitals by nine wickets in their IPL clash here on Monday, after unleashing a powerplay spell so vicious that it virtually ended the contest within the first three overs.

It was carnage of the highest order, a powerplay ambush so brutal that the Delhi Capitals never quite recovered as RCB unleashed a devastating new-ball spell to script one of the most dramatic openings in the IPL history.

Josh Hazlewood (4/12) and Bhuvneshwar Kumar (3/5) turned the powerplay into a demolition act, ripping through Delhi with two ruthless three-over bursts that left the hosts gasping at 13 for six.

Only Abhishek Porel (30), David Miller (19) and Kyle Jamieson (12) reached double-digit scores. The home team scored eight fours and a six.

All Delhi could manage was 75 in 16.3 overs but eventually deflected the ignominy of posting lowest IPL score. RCB had managed 49 in 2017 against Kolkata Knight Riders.

Chasing a modest target, RCB openers Virat Kohli (23) and Jacob Bethell (20) ensured a smooth start. There were no hiccups except that Bethell was



RCB's Josh Hazlewood gestures for the wicket of Delhi Capitals' Abhishek Porel

PTI

done in by an exceptional catch by T Natarajan off Kyle Jamieson. Devdutt Padikkal scored a fluent 34 as some solid RCB batting took the game away from Delhi in no time..

Kohli's trademark composure combined with Padikkal's free-flowing strokeplay made the chase a mere formality as the duo raced past the finish line with ease in 6.3 overs, capping off a dominant night for the visitors.

The packed house came to watch their favourite batter but

13/6
DC scored 13 runs for 6 wickets in the powerplay, the lowest-ever powerplay score in IPL history

Kohli didn't get the opportu-

nity to enthrall his fans much due to a small target. The local boy, ended the match with consecutive sixes off T Natarajan.

From the dizzying high of piling up 264 in a batting spectacle that still somehow ended in defeat against Punjab Kings, the fall for Delhi was dramatic.

The same batting unit that was brimming with intent suddenly appeared tentative, brittle, and out of answers, undone by relentless pressure and disciplined bowling..

It was a stark reminder of

the format's unforgiving nature, where dominance can swiftly give way to disarray, and confidence can evaporate almost overnight.

The RCB bowlers reduced Delhi to survival mode inside the first three overs, their relentless accuracy and movement turning the contest one-sided almost instantly. The mayhem began as early as the second ball of the innings when Bhuvneshwar Kumar produced an in-dipping yorker to uproot debutant Sahil Parakh's middle stump, setting the tone for what followed: absolute destruction.

If that was a warning shot, Hazlewood turned it into a full-blown collapse. The Australian quick sent shockwaves through the packed stadium by removing last-match centurion KL Rahul (1) and Sameer Rizvi (0) off successive deliveries.

Rahul miscued a pull after the ball grew big on him, while Rizvi edged one as he played away from his body without any visible footwork. There was no respite. Bhuvneshwar, in complete command of swing and seam, returned to deepen Delhi's misery by dismissing Tristan Stubbs (5). Stubbs tried to jab at a length delivery and the outside edge flew safely into the hands of Devdutt Padikkal at slip. AGENCIES

MULLANPUR: Riyan Parag, a captain short of runs, will need to lead from the front to challenge a peerless Punjab Kings in their Indian Premier League match here on Tuesday.

In the Shreyas Iyer-Ricky Ponting era that began last year, Punjab Kings have scripted a sensational turnaround, making them the most consistent and assuring unit in the competition, attributes they longed for ages.

Virat Kohli owned the tag of chase-master with his remarkable consistency over the years and now Iyer too is on that path. As a leader and batter, he has displayed commendable calm in high-pressure situations to help Punjab Kings stay unbeaten in the tournament thus far.

Iyer has led brilliantly but the team as a whole too has functioned like a well oiled unit. Last season, they managed to defend the lowest total in IPL history and on a scorching Saturday in New Delhi, Iyer and Co. gunned down a record 265-run target with ridiculous ease.

The six wins in seven games (one washout) has also been made possible by the destructive opening duo of Priyansh Arya and Prabhsimran Singh, who put their team on course



Punjab Kings' Shreyas Iyer will look to make bowlers' life difficult

FILE

Punjab have scripted sensational turnaround, making them the most consistent and assuring unit

for a historic chase at Kotla by hammering 116 runs in the powerplay.

Punjab Kings bowlers took a beating in that match but considering the batting friendly conditions and small ground dimensions, they could not be blamed much.

Playing their last game of the season here before hosting their final three league games of the season in Dharamsala,

Punjab Kings will be expected to steamroll Rajasthan Royals.

The Royals have lost momentum in the middle phase of the tournament having won their first four games. While teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi has produced jaw dropping performances, the team has not been able to maintain consistency.

Eight games into the season, captain Parag has failed to deliver in the middle order, collecting just 88 runs in eight innings at an underwhelming strike rate of 112.82. The pressure on him is mounting with every game. Sunrisers Hyderabad were able to chase down 229 against the Royals comfortably in the night game on Saturday. Their fielding too left a lot to be desired. AGENCIES

PANT ALSO BACKS HIM

Langer defends Pooran gamble in Super Over



LSG's Nicholas Pooran is bowled by KKR's Sunil Narine

PTI

LUCKNOW: Lucknow Super Giants head coach Justin Langer defended sending out-of-form Nicholas Pooran to face Kolkata Knight Riders' star spinner Sunil Narine in the Super Over of their IPL match, saying the team management thought the explosive West Indian batter was the best option despite his lean run.

Pooran, who has laboured for runs this IPL season with 22 being his highest, got out first ball bowled by Narine and LSG ended up at 1 for 2 in the Super Over. KKR needed just one ball to win the match.

"Good question. We knew that Sunil Narine had bowled it, and if you look at Nicky's (Nicholas Pooran) record, he's seen Sunil Narine more than anyone in world cricket. So we felt that he was still the best option," Langer said at the post-match press conference.

"I know he hasn't hit his form yet, and Nicky will be the first to admit that, but we thought if anyone can handle a Super Over, it's Nicky Pooran. You back your best players. He has struggled, but if you look at all the numbers, no one plays Narine, the world-class off-spinner, better than Nicky. It didn't come off, unfortunately," he added.

"I know he hasn't hit his form yet, and Nicky will be the first to admit that, but we thought if anyone can handle a Super Over, it's Nicky Pooran"
Justin Langer , LSG coach

There was also a bit of history. The lone maiden Super Over in the history of T20 cricket was bowled by Narine in the Caribbean Premier League (CPL) in 2014, and Pooran was one of the batters who got out without scoring in that instance also.

"There's probably no greater T20 player (than Pooran) currently in the world over the last few years. It just goes to show he's human, and you can't fake confidence. We all try to. You can look confident, but confidence comes from getting your processes right," Langer said.

LSG captain Rishabh Pant had also defended the choice of Pooran to bat in the Super Over. AGENCIES

UCL: Bayern must adapt with coach Kompany suspended for semis at PSG

PARIS: Vincent Kompany's influence as coach is a key reason Bayern Munich is in the Champions League semifinals. Now Bayern will have to manage without him.

Bayern is preparing for arguably its toughest game of the season so far with its head coach suspended and assistant Aaron Danks reportedly due to take over.

Kompany was still involved in training Monday before Bayern's departure for Paris, but he'll be barred from the team's locker room and bench at the Parc des Princes on Tuesday.

"We'll miss him on the touchline. He's our boss, a coach who'd love to be out there with us," Harry Kane has said.

A costly yellow card
It's all because Kompany was booked in Bayern's thrilling quarterfinal win over Real

Missing Kompany command



Bayern Munich will bank on their star power up front

AP

Madrid for disputing the referee's decision to allow Madrid to play on and score after a hard tackle on Bayern defender Josip Stanisic.

That was Kompany's third yellow card in what was Bayern's 12th Champions League game of the season. He argued UEFA should relax the rules

now there are more games than ever. "It's an extended format and it's the strictest-ever ruling with a lot of interpretation from referees, where sometimes you can get a yellow card wrong as

Coco overcomes vomiting and Cirstea

MADRID: Coco Gauff has advanced to the fourth round of the Madrid Open despite falling ill and vomiting on court.

Gauff, a finalist in Madrid last year, rallied to beat Sorana Cirstea 4-6, 7-5, 6-1 on Sunday. The American threw up on court in the middle of the second set.

"When I actually threw up on the court, that was like a little bit embarrassing," Gauff said. "Then after that first game and the second, I was like that took everything out of me."

On Saturday, fourth-ranked Iga Swiatek withdrew due to an unspecified illness while

playing her round-of-32 match against American Ann Li.

Gauff said she was determined to carry on her match. "I'm someone who doesn't like to pull out. I don't like to do that unless I really feel like I have no other options," Gauff said.

"So the plan was to always just try to finish, even if it ended up with me just playing just to get through it." She recovered from a break down three times before winning the set 7-5.

The third-ranked Gauff said she doesn't know how she "got through that," and said she almost threw up in the middle of a point.



Lakshya Sen gave India a perfect start

BWF



Ayush Shetty produced a clinical display to outclass Shrey Dhand

BWF

as HS Prannoy comfortably beat Rishi Honda Boopathy

S Africa drub India; Harman says 'must find way a forward'

BENONI : India suffered yet another batting meltdown in a modest 156-run chase as South Africa rode on skipper Laura Wolvaardt's sublime unbeaten 92 to clinch a convincing 23-run win and seal the Women's T20I series 4-1 in dominant fashion.

Wolvaardt, who has already notched up two fifties and a century in the series, struck 11 fours and two sixes in her 56-ball knock, carrying her bat despite wickets falling around her.

Her late flourish -- two sixes off the final two balls -- lifted South Africa past the 150-mark after a middle-overs slowdown.

In reply, India were restricted to 132 for eight, with their experienced batters once again failing to deliver.

Skipper Harmanpreet Kaur laboured to 22 off 28 balls, while Shafali Verma (4), Jemimah Rodrigues (1) and Deepti Sharma (8) fell cheaply without much resistance. It was left to Bharti Fulmali to provide some fight with a counter-attacking 40 off 30 balls (4x4, 2x6), but India's middle-overs stagnation following a poor start proved costly.

South Africa's bowlers were disciplined throughout, with

Skipper Wolvaardt once again led from the front with an unbeaten 92 off 56 balls, anchoring the innings despite wickets falling at regular intervals

Nonkululeko Mlaba leading the charge with an impressive 2/15, including a maiden, and accounting for Harmanpreet. Nadine de Klerk also picked up two wickets.

It was a reality check for the WODI champions India ahead of the T20 World Cup in two months' time, as frequent changes in the XI and lack of consistency continued to hurt their campaign.

"Need to sit together as a group and think how to move forward. Disappointing for us, lots of positives and learnings for us," Harmanpreet said at the post-match presentation. "We did well in patches today. In batting, the powerplay was something which cost us. Didn't get too many runs and lost two wickets. It's disappointing, need to keep working hard." AGENCIES

Joshua to take on Prega in July

LONDON: Former two-time world heavyweight champion Anthony Joshua will fight for the first time since his involvement in a deadly car crash in December when he takes on Kristian Prega in Saudi Arabia in July. "It's no secret I've taken some time to consolidate and rebuild to be ready for stepping back into the ring," Joshua said in a statement from his promoter, Matchroom, "and today is the next step on that journey."

The 36-year-old Joshua will fight Prega, an Albanian with 20 victories and one loss, on July 25 in Riyadh in the headline bout in "The Comeback," which is part of Esports World Cup Festival.

Joshua's last fight was a knockout victory over YouTuber Jake Paul on Dec. 19. Ten days later, he was injured in a car crash in Nigeria that killed two of his friends.

In the Matchroom statement, Joshua said the fight with Prega is the first in a "multi-fight deal" that could yet include a long-anticipated bout with British rival Tyson Fury. Joshua was present when Fury, also a former two-time heavyweight champion, ended a 15-month retirement from the ring when beating Arslanbek Makhmudov at Tottenham Hotspur Stadium. AGENCIES

‘WAS SCARED TO WORK

WITH MERYL IN THE DEVIL WEARS PRADA’

Emily Blunt admitted she was intimidated by Streep while filming the first film

LONDON: Hollywood actress Emily Blunt admitted she was intimidated by Meryl Streep while filming the first ‘The Devil Wears Prada’ film.

Blunt, who is returning to reprise her role in the second instalment, spoke about the film and its sequel at the ‘SiriusXM Front Row’ chat hosted by Andy Cohen, where she was accompanied by her co-actors Anne Hathaway, Streep and Stanley Tucci, according to the entertainment news magazine ‘People’.

When asked if she was intimidated while working with Streep, Emily recalled the shooting of the first film and said she was ‘quite scared’.

“I mean, on the first one, I was quite scared because I felt like you were in a zone. She was in a Miranda zone,” Blunt told Streep, who essays Miranda Priestly, the cruel editor-in-chief of ‘Runway’ magazine in the film franchise.

Replying to the actress, Streep said, “Oh, yeah. I was in that zone.”

“Not impenetrable, but we could come up and tell you a funny story, but you wouldn’t do your extraordinary laugh that I normally hear,” Blunt added.

The first film revolved around Andy Sachs (Hathaway), a smart but fashion-clueless journalism graduate who moves to New York City with dreams of becoming a serious writer. Desperate for work, she lands a job as a junior personal assistant to Miranda Priestly, the cold and tyrannical editor-in-chief of the elite fashion magazine ‘Runway’.

‘The Devil Wears Prada 2’ will follow Streep’s character, Miranda Priestly, navigating the decline of traditional print media, forced to face off against her former assistant, Emily Charlton (Blunt), who is now a high-powered luxury group executive controlling vital advertising funds.

PTI



‘The Devil Wears Prada 2’ is set to release on May 1



Bobby Deol’s ‘BANDAR’ to release on June 5

It had its world premiere at the 50th Toronto International Film Festival



NEW DELHI: The makers of ‘Bandar’, featuring Bobby Deol, said the film will release in theatres worldwide on June 5. The film is directed by Anurag Kashyap and is written by Sudip Sharma and Abhishek Banerjee, according to a press release.

‘Bandar’, which had its world premiere at the 50th Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF) in September 2025, is said to be inspired by real-life events and follows the story of a fading star accused

It also features Sanya Malhotra, Raj B Shetty, Jitendra Joshi, Sapna Pabbi and others

of rape, shining a light on systemic injustices, silenced voices in courtrooms and the harsh realities of a deeply flawed legal framework.

It is produced by Nikhil Dwivedi and backed by ‘Zee Studios’ and also features Sanya Malhotra, Raj B Shetty, Jitendra Joshi, Sapna Pabbi, Indrajith Sukumaran, Riddhi Sen, Saba Azad and Nagesh Bhosle in pivotal roles.

Besides ‘Bandar’, Deol will also feature in the action-thriller ‘Alpha’ alongside Sharvati and Alia Bhatt. The film is directed by Shiv Rawail. He will also appear in the Tamil action-drama film ‘Jana Nayagan’. It is directed by H Vinodh.

PTI



Adah Sharma talked about sharing screen space with him in ‘Governor: The Silent Saviour’

‘The Night Manager 3’ won’t take as long as the last one: David

Farr is the creator and executive producer of the series

LOS ANGELES: The third season of ‘The Night Manager’, an adaptation of novelist John le Carré’s espionage thriller, will come sooner than the second one, which arrived after a decade. Creator and executive producer David Farr revealed that work is already in progress on a third instalment during Deadline’s Contenders TV panel for the show’s second run.

The story of the series revolves around a former British soldier and the night manager of a luxury hotel, who gets roped in by an intelligence officer to infiltrate the inner circle of a secretive arms dealer.

The first season, starring ‘Loki’ star Tom Hiddleston, Hugh Laurie, Olivia Colman, Tom Hollander, David Harewood and Elizabeth Debicki,



premiered in 2016 and became an instant hit. The second season of the ‘Prime Video/BBC’ series premiered in January this year.

“Right now, I feel the deep weight of doom of stress about it because I’m the one who has to actually do the writing of the damn thing. It’s a huge challenge. It’ll be very exciting. And it won’t take as long as the last

one, I promise,” Farr said, adding that viewers should expect the new season to address the dark ending of the second part.

He said it was important to end on that note as ‘the world is a tough place at the moment and it didn’t feel right not to reflect that. But of course, all of us want to see justice, redemption and we want to see something change, so I feel like Season 3, there is actually a deep emotional and moral imperative to honour that’.

Hiddleston, who reprised his role as Jonathan Pine, praised Le Carré as a genius and one of the great writers of the 20th century. He said he loved the character he played in the series.

“I’ve been waiting to do this again for so long. I love this character. I’m so inspired by his courage,” said the actor.

PTI

‘Happy to share screen space with Manoj sir’

Adah Sharma, who will be seen sharing screen space with Manoj Bajpayee in the upcoming film ‘Governor’, shared that she is very happy to work with him and tagged the National Award-winning actor as ‘awesome’.

Talking about working with Manoj for the very first time, Adah told IANS, “He is the face of the film. He plays the governor in ‘Governor’ and he is awesome.”

“I’m very happy to share screen space with him. We have an excellent director and fab actor, Chinmay Mandekar. There’s a nice surprise to my character also and it’s something I haven’t done before,” said Adah without revealing many details about her character from the upcoming movie.

It was on Manoj’s birthday on April 23 when the film’s poster was revealed. Filmmaker Vipul Amrutlal Shah unveiled the poster on his ‘Instagram’ handle. Without revealing much, the first poster of ‘Governor: The Silent Saviour’, directed by Chinmay Mandekar, features Manoj from the back, walking down a corridor with a suitcase, alongside the tagline, “If I fail... India fails,” hinting at a high-octane legal drama.

In another poster, a green chair is highlighted with the taglines ‘India is on the verge of bankruptcy’ and ‘Yeh sirf kursi nahi... zimmedaari hai’, which point to

an intense narrative centred on the nation.

‘Governor: The Silent Saviour’ is produced by Vipul Amrutlal Shah and directed by Chinmay Mandekar. The film is co-produced by Aashin A Shah and written by Suwendu Bhattacharyjee, Saurabh Bharat, Ravi Asrani and Vipul Amrutlal Shah.

The 33-year-old actress stepped into the world of glitz and glamour in 2008 with ‘1920’, a horror movie. She was then seen in films such as ‘Hasee Toh Phasee’, ‘Commando’, ‘Heart Attack’, ‘S/O Satyamurthy and Kshanam’. She shot to major fame with her work in the 2023 film ‘The Kerala Story’.

AGENCIES

Racism is Bollywood’s biggest issue: Nawazuddin

Despite his noteworthy versatility in roles, he has often opened up about facing racism in Bollywood

Despite his noteworthy versatility in roles, Nawazuddin Siddiqui has often opened up about facing racism in Bollywood. The actor, who has been a part of the film industry for over 20 years, even revealed getting rejected from projects because of his complexion. In a recent interview, he got candid about staying confident amid the beauty standards and discrimination in Bollywood. Nawazuddin also mentioned that he has never found anyone more beautiful than the late actress, Smita Patil.

The actor’s comments reflect how inherent colourism has been in Bollywood, with lighter skin often equated with a higher social status. Despite the parallel cinema movement bringing about a change in the 1970s and 1980s, where actors like Smita Patil and Shabana Azmi emerged as the icons, the leads in mainstream cinema have largely remained fair-skinned, with a few exceptions, such as Irrfan Khan and Nawazuddin.

During a conversation with ‘Zoom’, the actor admitted experiencing racism and elaborated on how the industry has still embraced him. He agreed that it’s not nepotism but racism that has a bigger impact in the Hindi film industry. “As the saying goes, when you eliminate a cockroach, people commend you for it. But when you eliminate a butterfly, they question your actions. This selectivity exists. Just as there is a lot of selectivity in discrimination, it is present in many areas. I believe that you shouldn’t dictate what beauty is; let individuals make that decision,” he said.



The 51-year-old further added that a female actress who is considered ‘dark-skinned’ is considered average here. But, in the West, she may be viewed as exotic. “People have their own perspectives. But that shouldn’t influence the system. If she looks a certain way, she may not be cast as the lead. It’s not entirely their fault, as narratives are crafted in this manner. A girl who is fair, stories are written about her. You get a brief. Many people are struggling with this issue.”

Nawazuddin also pointed out that he personally finds the late actress Smita Patil the most beautiful ever. “There are numerous factors to consider. The beauty captured by the camera is unique. Personally, I have never encountered anyone I find more beautiful than Smita Patil. The camera’s beauty is distinct and we need to capture that essence. The camera doesn’t pass judgment,” he expressed.



Nawazuddin also mentioned that he has never found anyone more beautiful than the late actress Smita Patil

AGENCIES

#ViralFeed

Kriti Sanon

vamped up in a sexy black bodycon attire with smoking black kohl eyes

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